SOFTWARE ARCHITECTURE & CONSULTING DEPARTMENT

Software Architecture & Consulting Handbook

From zero to professional: training, consulting lifecycle, governance, documentation, costing and client delivery

Developed by VEL Software Solutions
Software Architecture & Technical Consulting Department
velsoftwaresolutions.in@gmail.com

Document VEL-SA-001 · Version 1.0 (draft for management approval) · 4 November 2026
Standards, tool versions, limits and prices change. Always verify against official sources before building, quoting or citing. Structural, security and compliance statements are advice for qualified review, not certification.

Contents

How to Use This Handbook 3
1. Commercial Service Portfolio 4
2. Department Structure and Roles 6
3. Learning Roadmap: Levels 1-7 8
4. Architecture Patterns and Evaluation 13
5. Tools and When to Use Each 17
6. Mandatory Consulting Lifecycle (15 Stages) 19
7. Architecture Repository Structure 30
8. Deliverable and Review Standards 33
9. Commercial Costing and Pricing 36
10. Beginner Onboarding Guide 44
11. First Architecture Diagram Exercise 46
12. Teaching Lessons (15-Part Format) 49
13. Practical Training Projects 55
90-Day Training Roadmap 57
14. Official Learning Sources and Standards 59
15. Reference Diagrams 62
Glossary 65
Appendix A: 15-Part Lesson Template 66
Appendix B: Architecture Assessment Template 67
Appendix C: Client Discovery Questionnaire 70
Appendix D: Architecture Decision Record Template 74
Appendix E: Requirements Specification Template 75
Appendix F: Technical Feasibility Report Template 78
Appendix G: Technology Comparison Matrix 80
Appendix H: Risk and Assumption Register Template 82
Appendix I: Stakeholder Map Template 83
Appendix J: Architecture Review Checklist 84
Appendix K: Cost Estimation Template 87
Appendix L: Client Presentation Template 89
Appendix M: Engineering Handover Checklist 91

How to Use This Handbook

This handbook is the single operating manual for the **Software Architecture & Technical Consulting Department**. It does two jobs: **(1)** it trains a beginner into a professional who can support client projects under senior architectural supervision, and **(2)** it defines the mandatory 15-stage consulting lifecycle, with owners, reviewers, approval gates and deliverable standards.

GOLDEN RULES OF THE DEPARTMENT

1. Architecture is a set of **decisions with reasons**, not a set of diagrams. Every diagram must trace to a requirement and every significant choice to an ADR.
2. Never present an unverified assumption as a confirmed client fact. Label it **ASSUMPTION** with an owner and a date to confirm.
3. Do not recommend a pattern or technology because it is popular. Compare at least two viable options and write down the trade-offs.
4. Juniors prepare research, documentation and diagrams. Juniors **never** approve high-impact decisions.
5. We never certify a client as "secure" or "compliant" and never guarantee uptime, savings or performance without evidence. We offer readiness support and *reasoned recommendations*.
6. Prices, tool versions, standards editions and cloud limits change. Verify against the official source before you build, quote or cite.
7. Every approved architecture decision needs a second person's review. No one reviews their own work.

Reading path for a beginner

Part A: Onboard (Ch. 10-11) → Part B: Learn Levels 1-7 (Ch. 3-5) → Part C: Lifecycle (Ch. 6-8) →
Part D: Business (Ch. 2, 9) → Part E: Projects and sources (Ch. 13-14)

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES

Client names such as **GreenLeaf Organics** are fictional training examples. Prices are illustrative defaults for training, not quotes. Replace them with approved company rates before use.

DOCUMENT STATUS

Document VEL-SA-001 · Version 1.0 · prepared 4 November 2026 · draft for management approval. Standards and tool facts in this handbook were written from the author's knowledge; the official links in Chapter 14 could not be machine-checked in the build environment, so open each one and confirm the current edition before relying on it.

1. Commercial Service Portfolio

Eighteen commercially deliverable services. Each can be sold alone or combined. Every service ends in a **reviewed written deliverable**, never only a conversation.

Service	What we deliver	Typical client trigger
Software architecture consulting	Independent advice on structure, patterns and risks for a new or existing system	"We are about to build and want it right."
Solution architecture	End-to-end design of one solution across apps, data, integration and infrastructure	"We need a design before we hire developers."
Enterprise architecture advisory	Capability maps, target state, standards and roadmaps across many systems	"We have 40 systems and no shared direction."
Technical feasibility studies	Evidence-based yes/no/with-conditions on technology, cost, skills, time and compliance	"Can this even be done within budget?"
Technology selection	Weighted comparison of languages, frameworks, databases, platforms	"Which stack should we choose?"
Application architecture reviews	Structured review against quality attributes; findings and fixes ranked by risk	"It works but nobody dares change it."
Cloud architecture design	Landing zone, network, compute, data, DR and cost design on AWS / Azure / GCP	"Move us to the cloud without surprises."
Database architecture	Logical and physical models, engine choice, scaling, backup and migration	"Reports take minutes; data is inconsistent."
API architecture	REST/event API style, contracts (OpenAPI), versioning, security, governance	"Partners integrate in ten different ways."
Microservices assessment	Is a split justified? Boundaries, data ownership, operational readiness	"Everyone says we need microservices."
Monolith modernisation	Incremental path (modular monolith, strangler pattern) with risk-ranked steps	"Release takes 3 weeks and breaks things."
Legacy system assessment	Inventory, risk, cost-of-ownership, retire / retain / rehost / refactor / replace	"The only developer who knows it is leaving."
System integration architecture	Integration patterns, canonical data, error handling, monitoring	"Systems disagree and re-key data by hand."
Security architecture coordination	Trust boundaries, threat model, control mapping; coordinates with security specialists	"A customer asked about our security."
Scalability and performance reviews	Load model, bottleneck analysis, capacity plan, test strategy	"Black Friday took us down."

Service	What we deliver	Typical client trigger
Technical due diligence	Independent assessment of a target's technology, debt, team and risk for investors	"We are acquiring / investing; what are we buying?"
Architecture documentation	C4 diagrams, ADRs, interface specs, runbooks and handover packs	"No one knows how it fits together."
Digital transformation roadmaps	Phased, costed roadmap tying business goals to technology change	"Leadership wants a 3-year plan."

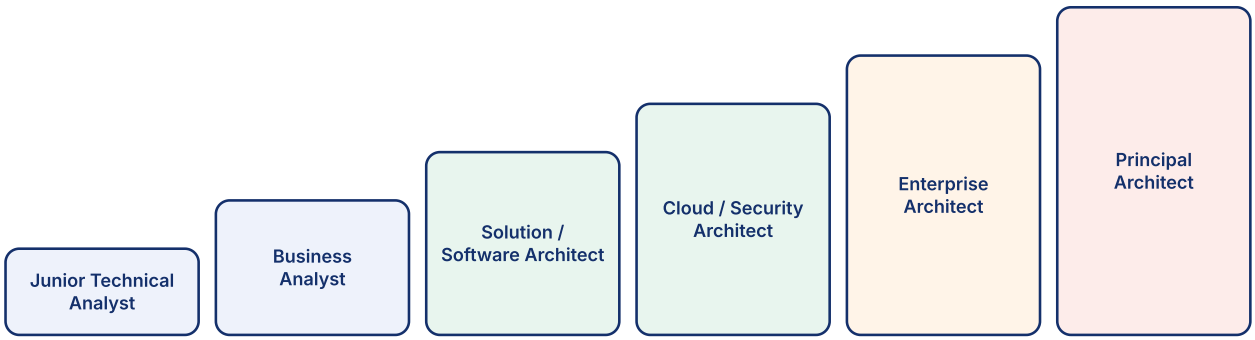
COMPLIANCE AND ASSURANCE WORDING

We say "security architecture coordination" and "compliance readiness support." We do not certify, audit-opine or guarantee. Formal certification (for example ISO/IEC 27001) is performed by accredited bodies. Technical due diligence reports state their scope and evidence limits.

2. Department Structure and Roles

A junior employee may prepare research, documentation and diagrams but **must not independently approve high-impact architecture decisions**. High-impact means any decision that is costly to reverse, affects security or data protection, changes cost by more than 10%, creates vendor lock-in, or touches more than one team.

Role	Core responsibilities	Decision authority	Typical entry
Junior Technical Analyst	Research, notes, diagrams, documentation, draft ADRs, comparison tables	Prepares only. Cannot approve architecture decisions or send client advice unreviewed.	Months 0-12
Business Analyst	Stakeholder interviews, process maps, requirements, acceptance criteria, traceability	Owns the requirements baseline; signs requirement completeness.	Level 2 mastered
Solution Architect	End-to-end design for one engagement; alternatives, target architecture, handover	Approves medium-impact design; proposes high-impact decisions.	Level 5 mastered
Software Architect	Application structure, patterns, code-level standards, API and data design	Approves application-level design; reviews implementation compliance.	Level 4-5
Cloud Architect	Cloud landing zone, networking, DR, cost, IaC standards	Approves cloud design and cost model.	Level 5 + cloud certs advised
Security Architect	Threat models, trust boundaries, control mapping, security review	Veto on unresolved high security risks; signs security section.	Level 5-6
Enterprise Architect	Cross-system capability maps, standards, roadmaps, governance	Approves cross-programme direction and standards.	Level 7
Principal Architect	Department technical authority, review board chair, due-diligence sign-off	Final approval of high-impact decisions and client-facing architecture.	Senior
Project Manager	Scope, schedule, budget, risks, change control, client communication	Approves scope change and commercial terms with the sponsor.	Any



Authority to approve high-impact decisions grows to the right; juniors prepare, seniors approve.

Figure 2.1 Approval authority grows with seniority.

Decision-impact matrix

Impact	Examples	Who may approve
Low	Diagram styling, naming, tool template choice	Any architect or the author's reviewer
Medium	Library choice, module boundaries, API style within an approved architecture	Solution or Software Architect
High	Database engine, cloud provider, monolith vs microservices, security model, DR strategy, any commitment above 10% cost change	Principal Architect plus client sponsor; recorded as an ADR

RACI for a standard engagement

R = does the work · A = accountable and approves · C = consulted · S = supports · I = informed.

R = does the work · A = accountable and approves · C = consulted · S = supports · I = informed.

3. Learning Roadmap: Levels 1-7

For **every** subject the trainee receives the 15-part teaching pack (Chapter 12). The tables below are the syllabus. A level is passed only when all exercises are demonstrated and reviewed by a Principal or Solution Architect.

Level 1 — Software Fundamentals (weeks 1-2)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Software lifecycle	The stages software passes through: idea, requirements, design, build, test, release, operate, retire.	Architecture decisions are cheapest at the start and costliest after release.	Map a recent app you use to the lifecycle stages.
Requirements	A statement of what the system must do or be.	Wrong requirements produce the right system for the wrong problem.	Rewrite 5 vague wishes as testable requirements.
Frontend and backend	Frontend runs on the user's device; backend runs on servers and holds rules and data.	Security checks must live in the backend; the browser can be tampered with.	Open browser dev tools; identify requests the page makes.
Databases	Organised, durable storage with rules for access.	Data outlives code; bad data design is the hardest to fix.	Design two related tables (customer, order); explain the key.
APIs	A contract by which one program asks another to do something.	APIs are how systems integrate; changing them breaks others.	Call a public API with Postman; read the status code and JSON.
Servers	Computers (physical or virtual) that run software 24×7.	Capacity, location and failure of servers drive availability.	List what happens if the only server loses power.
Networks	How devices exchange data: IP, DNS, ports, HTTP/S, firewalls.	Most "the site is down" faults are network faults.	Trace DNS for a domain with nslookup/dig; explain each answer.
Cloud fundamentals	Renting compute, storage and services on demand (IaaS, PaaS, SaaS).	Cloud shifts cost from capital to operating and changes failure modes.	Compare IaaS/PaaS/SaaS for hosting a website; give one example each.
Security fundamentals	Confidentiality, integrity, availability; authentication vs authorisation.	Security is a design property, not a patch.	Explain CIA triad using an online bank example.

Level 2 — Business Analysis (weeks 3-4)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Stakeholder identification	People who affect or are affected by the system.	Missing one stakeholder is the commonest cause of late rework.	Build a power/interest grid for the GreenLeaf case.
Discovery interviews	Structured conversations to learn goals, pain and constraints.	Clients describe solutions; we must uncover problems.	Run a 30-minute mock interview with the questionnaire (Appendix C).
Business objectives	Measurable outcomes the organisation wants.	Architecture is justified by objectives, not technology taste.	Turn "grow online" into 3 measurable objectives.
Functional requirements	What the system does (features, rules, data).	Basis for scope, estimates and tests.	Write 10 requirements in "The system shall..." form with IDs.
Non-functional requirements	How well it does it: performance, availability, security, etc.	NFRs drive architecture more than features do.	Give each NFR a number: "p95 < 500 ms at 200 users".
Business process mapping	Diagram of how work flows today and tomorrow.	Reveals manual steps and hand-offs that systems must support.	Draw order-to-delivery as a swimlane.
User journeys	A user's steps, thoughts and pain points to reach a goal.	Surfaces missing features and failure paths.	Map the checkout journey including a failed payment.
Constraints	Fixed limits: budget, date, skills, law, existing systems.	Constraints rule options out early.	List 8 constraints; mark each confirmed or assumed.
Risks	Uncertain events that could harm objectives.	Unmanaged risk becomes schedule and cost overrun.	Score 6 risks on likelihood x impact with owners.
Acceptance criteria	Testable conditions that define "done".	Prevents disputes at handover.	Write Given/When/Then for 3 requirements.

Level 3 — Software Architecture Fundamentals (weeks 5-6)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Architecture vs design	Architecture = significant, hard-to-change decisions; design = detail inside them.	We spend review time where change is costly.	Classify 10 decisions as architectural or design, with reasons.
Components and modules	Replaceable parts with a clear responsibility.	Enable parallel work and change isolation.	Split a food-ordering app into modules.
Interfaces and dependencies	The agreed surface between parts; who needs whom.	Most failures happen at boundaries.	Draw a dependency graph; find a cycle and fix it.

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Separation of concerns	Each part handles one kind of thing.	Makes change local and testing simple.	Refactor a "god class" description into 4 concerns.
Coupling and cohesion	Coupling: how much parts depend on each other. Cohesion: how related a part's content is.	Aim for low coupling, high cohesion.	Score two designs for coupling; justify.
Layered architecture	Stack of layers; each uses the one below.	Simple, well understood; default for many business apps.	Draw the three-tier diagram (Chapter 11).
Modular monolith	One deployable unit with strict internal module boundaries.	Often the best starting point; cheap to run.	Define module boundaries and allowed dependencies.
Microservices	Independently deployable services owning their data.	Gives team autonomy; costs distribution complexity.	Complete Training Project 4 (comparison).
Event-driven systems	Parts communicate by publishing and reacting to events.	Decouples producers from consumers.	Model "order placed" with 3 consumers; list failure cases.
Distributed systems	Systems spread over networked machines that can fail independently.	Network is unreliable; consistency, latency and failure must be designed.	Explain CAP trade-off with a shopping-cart example.

Level 4 — Architecture Patterns (weeks 7-8)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
See Chapter 4	Ten patterns with benefits, costs, complexity and trade-offs.	Patterns are tools; wrong tool = wasted money.	For each pattern, write one situation where you would NOT use it.

Level 5 — Technical Architecture (weeks 9-10)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Application architecture	Structure of the software: layers, modules, runtime.	Determines change cost.	Produce C4 L2-L3 for the case study.
Database architecture	Data model, engine, replication, backup, scaling.	Data is the longest-lived asset.	Design ERD + backup plan (Project 3).
API architecture	Style (REST, events), contracts, versioning, auth.	Governs integration cost.	Write an OpenAPI skeleton (Project 5).
Integration architecture	How systems exchange data reliably.	Prevents re-keying and silent data loss.	Design retry + dead-letter handling.

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Cloud architecture	Regions, zones, compute, storage, managed services.	Drives availability and cost.	Complete Project 6.
Network architecture	Subnets, routing, gateways, firewalls, DNS.	Limits blast radius of attack.	Draw the network diagram with trust zones.
Security architecture	Identity, encryption, trust boundaries, logging.	Required for client trust.	STRIDE-analyse one data flow.
Deployment architecture	How software reaches and runs in environments.	Determines release risk.	Describe dev/test/prod and promotion steps.
Monitoring architecture	Logs, metrics, traces, alerts, dashboards.	You cannot operate what you cannot see.	Choose 5 golden signals and alert thresholds.
Disaster recovery	Plan to restore service after major failure (RTO/RPO).	Backups untested are hopes.	Define RTO/RPO for 3 tiers of system.

Level 6 — Architecture Evaluation (weeks 11-12)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Quality attributes	Scalability, availability, reliability, performance, security, maintainability, interoperability, portability.	These are the criteria for judging alternatives.	See evaluation table in Chapter 4.
Cost and complexity	Total cost of ownership, plus cognitive and operational complexity.	Cheap to build can be costly to run.	Compute 3-year TCO for two options.
Vendor lock-in	Cost of leaving a provider or product.	Affects negotiating power and risk.	Rate lock-in 1-5 and write an exit plan.
Operational capability	Whether the client can actually run the design.	A brilliant design nobody can operate fails.	Skills-gap table for the client team.

Level 7 — Architecture Governance (weeks 13+)

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Architecture Decision Records	Short documents capturing one decision, context, options and consequences.	Preserve the "why".	Write ADR-001 (Project 7).
Technical standards	Approved defaults (languages, patterns, naming, security baselines).	Reduce variation and review cost.	Draft a 1-page API standard.

Topic	Simple definition	Why it matters	Exercise and check
Review boards and design reviews	Scheduled expert review of designs.	Catches high-impact flaws early.	Run a mock design review with a checklist.
Change management	Controlled handling of changes to scope and architecture.	Stops silent drift.	Process one change request end to end.
Technical debt	Accumulated shortcuts that raise future cost.	Must be visible and managed.	Create a debt register with interest and priority.
Architecture compliance	Checking implementation matches approved design.	Closes the loop from design to delivery.	Perform a compliance review on a sample repo.
Documentation lifecycle	Create, review, publish, update, retire documents.	Stale documents mislead.	Define owners and review cadence for each artefact.

4. Architecture Patterns and Evaluation

Explain **benefits, costs, complexity and trade-offs** of every pattern. **Do not recommend a pattern because it is popular.** A pattern is justified only by a requirement it satisfies better than the simpler alternative.

THE SIMPLICITY TEST

Before proposing any pattern, ask: (1) which requirement does it serve? (2) what is the simplest option that could meet it? (3) what new failure modes and skills does it add? (4) can the client team operate it? If you cannot answer all four, do not propose it.

Pattern	What it is	Benefits	Costs / trade-offs	Complexity	Use when	Avoid when
MVC / MVP / MVVM	Separates data (model), screen (view) and input handling (controller).	Clear UI structure; testable logic; widely known.	Controllers can bloat; not a whole-system architecture.	Low	Server-rendered web apps, desktop apps.	Systems whose complexity is in the domain rules, not the UI.
Layered / N-tier	Presentation, business, data layers each using the one below.	Simple; easy onboarding; fits CRUD.	Can become a "big ball" with leaky layers; changes ripple vertically.	Low	Typical business apps, first version.	Highly independent scaling needs per feature.
Clean Architecture	Concentric rings; dependencies point inward to business rules.	Framework-independent core; testable; long-lived.	More files and mapping code; learning curve.	Medium	Long-lived, rule-heavy systems.	Short-lived prototypes or simple CRUD.
Hexagonal (ports and adapters)	Core exposes ports; adapters connect UI, DB, services.	Swap infrastructure easily; test core in isolation.	Indirection; discipline needed.	Medium	Many integrations; need testability.	Tiny apps where indirection exceeds value.
Domain-Driven Design	Model software around the business domain with bounded contexts.	Shared language with business; sound boundaries.	Needs domain experts' time; heavy for simple domains.	High	Complex domains; many teams.	Simple data entry systems.
Repository pattern	Abstraction over data access as a collection.	Decouples logic from storage; testable.	Can be redundant over modern ORMs; leaky abstractions.	Low	When storage may change or tests need fakes.	Where the ORM already gives the same abstraction.
CQRS	Separate models for commands (writes) and queries (reads).	Optimise reads and writes independently; clearer intent.	Two models to maintain; eventual consistency if stores split.	High	Read-heavy vs write-heavy asymmetry; reporting needs.	Plain CRUD with similar read/write shapes.
Event sourcing	Store every state change as an event; derive state by replay.	Full audit trail; time travel; rebuild projections.	Steep learning; event versioning; query complexity.	Very high	Audit-critical domains (finance, ledgers).	Most business apps; a normal audit table suffices.
Message-driven architecture	Components communicate via asynchronous messages through a broker.	Loose coupling; load levelling; resilience to downtime.	Debugging; ordering and duplicates; broker operations.	Medium-High	Spiky load; long tasks; integration.	Simple request/response needing immediate answers.

Pattern	What it is	Benefits	Costs / trade-offs	Complexity	Use when	Avoid when
API gateway	Single entry point handling routing, auth, rate limits.	Central security and policy; hides internals.	Single point of failure and bottleneck if poor; extra hop.	Medium	Many services/clients; public APIs.	One small app with one client.
Backend-for-frontend (BFF)	A backend tailored to each client type (web, mobile).	Client-specific payloads; independent evolution.	More services; duplicated logic.	Medium	Distinct client needs.	One client type.

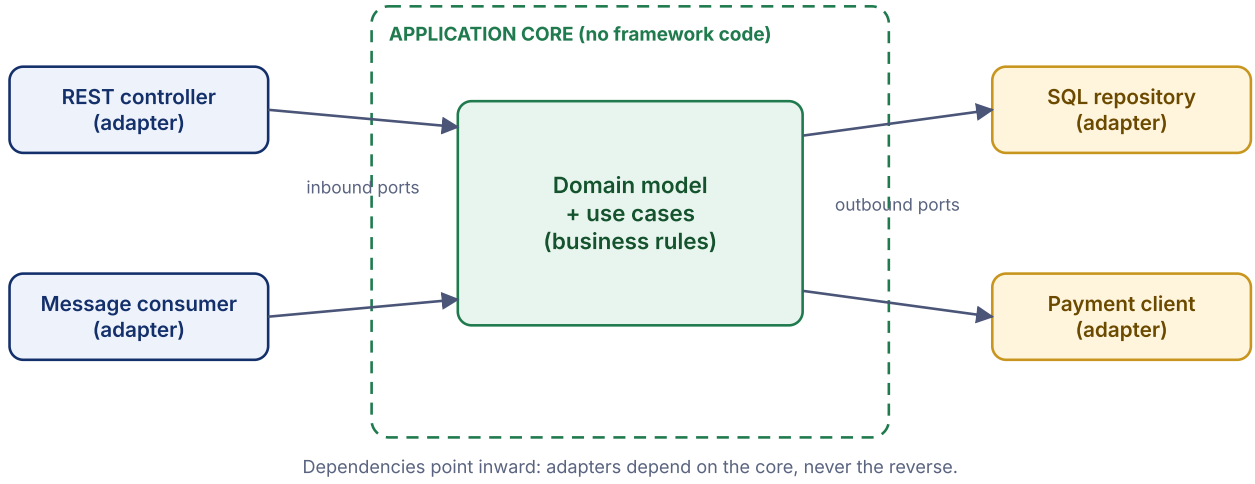


Figure 4.1 Hexagonal architecture (ports and adapters).

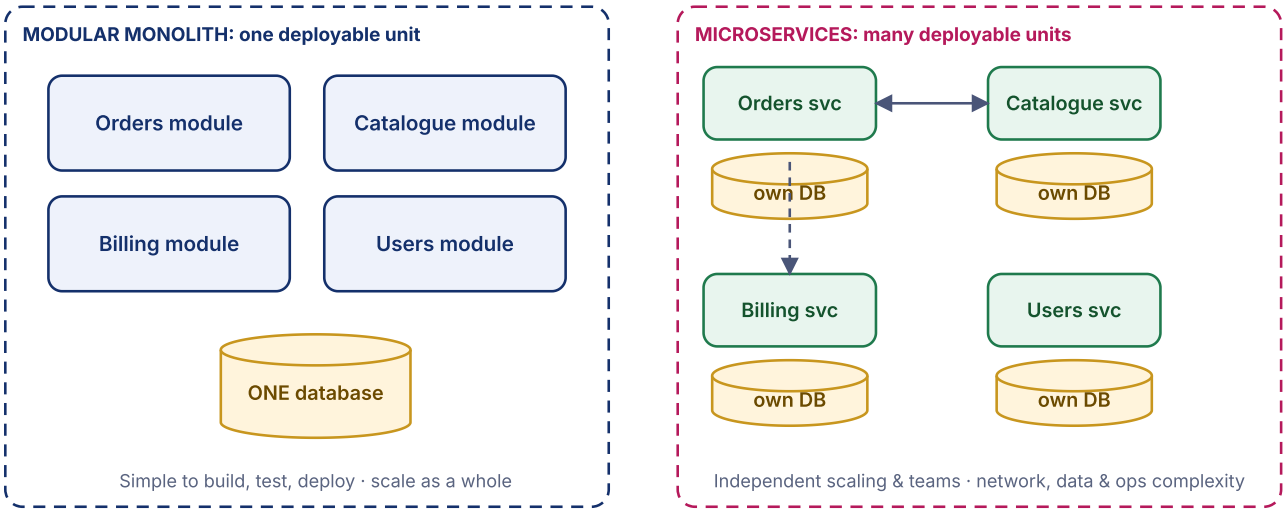
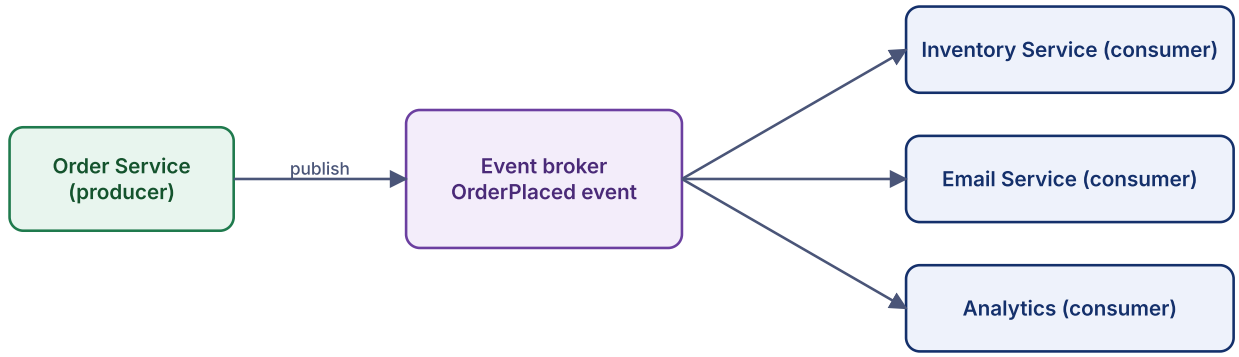


Figure 4.2 Modular monolith versus microservices.



Producers do not know who consumes. Gains decoupling; costs eventual consistency and harder debugging.

Figure 4.3 Event-driven architecture.

Monolith or microservices? Decision guide

Question	Points to modular monolith	Points to microservices
Team size	Under ~15 engineers or one team	Many autonomous teams
Release independence	Releases can be coordinated	Teams must deploy independently
Scaling	Load is uniform	Specific parts need very different scaling
Domain knowledge	Boundaries still unclear	Boundaries are stable and well known
Operations maturity	Little DevOps experience	CI/CD, observability and on-call already mature
Consistency	Needs strong transactions across features	Eventual consistency acceptable

DEFAULT ADVICE

For most clients, start with a **modular monolith** and extract services only where a measured need exists. State this reasoning in the ADR so the decision survives later fashion changes.

Architecture evaluation criteria (Level 6)

Attribute	Ask	Evidence / measure
Scalability	Can it handle 10x load by adding resources?	Load test; bottleneck analysis; capacity model
Availability	What % uptime is needed and what is the failure domain?	Target SLO (e.g. 99.9% = about 8.8 h downtime/year); redundancy design
Reliability	Does it behave correctly under faults?	Failure-mode analysis; retry/timeout design; chaos tests

Attribute	Ask	Evidence / measure
Performance	Response time and throughput at expected load?	p95/p99 latency targets; profiling
Security	Which threats are mitigated and which accepted?	Threat model; control mapping; test reports
Maintainability	How costly is a typical change?	Module coupling; test coverage; change lead time
Interoperability	Can it exchange data with required systems?	Open standards; contract tests
Portability	Can it move between hosts/clouds?	Containers; standard interfaces; exit cost
Cost	Build + run + change cost over 3 years?	TCO model; cloud calculator
Complexity	How many moving parts and skills required?	Component count; skills matrix
Vendor lock-in	Cost and time to leave?	Proprietary service inventory; exit plan
Operational capability	Can the client run and support it?	Skills gap; runbooks; on-call model

AVAILABILITY NUMBERS

99.9% availability allows about 8.76 hours of downtime per year (0.001 × 8,760 h). 99.99% allows about 52.6 minutes. Calculate, show the formula, and never promise a number the design and budget cannot support.

5. Tools and When to Use Each

Choose the tool for the **audience and the artefact**. Diagram-as-code is best for version control and review; visual editors are best for workshops and stakeholder polish.

Tool	Best for	Strengths	Watch out for	Licence / cost*
draw.io (diagrams.net)	Network, deployment, cloud and free-form diagrams	Free; large icon libraries; stores .drawio/.svg in Git	Layout drift; no semantic model	Open source, free
PlantUML	Sequence, class, component, C4 (via C4-PlantUML)	Text-based, diff-friendly; powerful	Syntax learning; automatic layout limits	Open source (verify edition)
Mermaid	Flowcharts, sequence, ER, simple C4 in Markdown	Renders natively in GitHub/GitLab Markdown	Limited layout control; C4 is experimental	Open source, MIT
C4 model	Notation to describe software at 4 zoom levels	Shared vocabulary for technical and business readers	Is a method, not a tool; keep levels consistent	Free to use (c4model.com)
Structurizr (DSL / Lite)	One model, many C4 views	Model-based consistency; DSL in Git	Hosted-service availability and pricing change: verify	DSL/Lite open source; check hosted plans
Figma / FigJam	Client presentations, workshops, visual polish	Collaboration; beautiful slides	Not source-controlled; not a model	Freemium; paid plans
GitHub	Version control, reviews, ADRs, docs-as-code, issues	Pull-request review; Actions; Markdown rendering	Do not store secrets or client confidential data in public repos	Free and paid plans
VS Code	Editing Markdown, PlantUML, Mermaid, IaC, API specs	Extensions; Git integrated; live preview	Extension trust and licences	Editor free
Cloud architecture tools	Vendor reference diagrams, cost calculators, well-architected tools	Official icons and patterns	Vendor bias; prices change	Calculators free
Threat modelling tools	STRIDE analysis, data-flow threat lists (OWASP Threat Dragon, Microsoft Threat Modeling Tool)	Structured threat discovery	Output needs expert review	Check each tool's licence
Database modelling tools	ERDs and schema design (dbdiagram, pgModeler, MySQL Workbench, draw.io)	Generates SQL; visual relations	Model drift from live schema	Varies; verify
Postman	Exploring and documenting APIs; collections; mock servers	Quick testing; sharing collections	Account/team limits; secrets in collections	Freemium
Terraform (documentation)	Reading and writing IaC, reviewing plans	Declarative infrastructure; large provider docs	Licence changes: evaluate OpenTofu; verify current terms	Check licence
Architecture documentation platforms	arc42 templates, MkDocs, Docusaurus, Confluence, Notion	Search, structure, publishing	Documents rot without owners	Varies

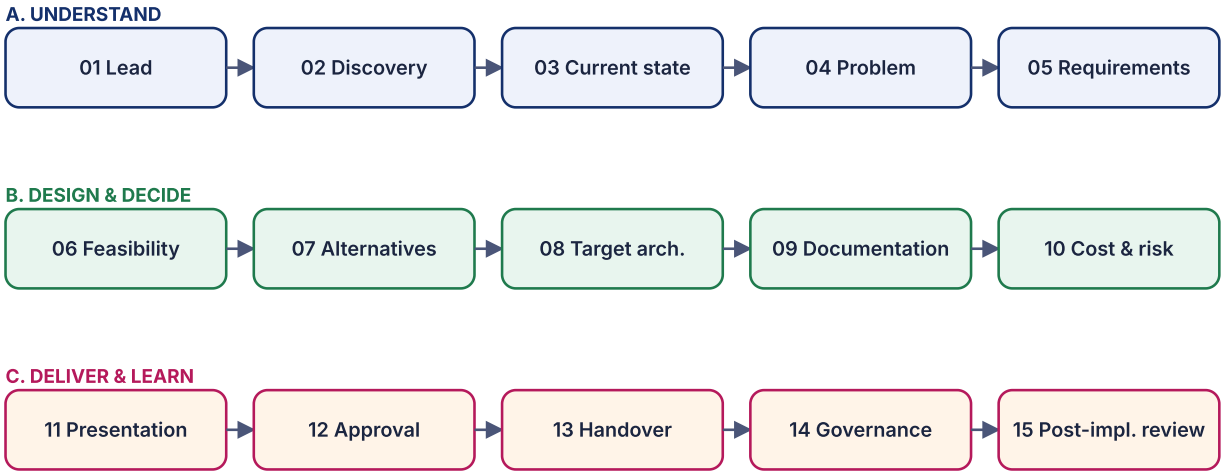
*Licences and prices change. Verify on the vendor's official site and record the check date in the project's tool register.

Which diagram for which question?

Question to answer	Diagram	Audience	Preferred tool
What is the system and who/what uses it?	C4 Level 1 System Context	Everyone, including executives	Structurizr, PlantUML, draw.io
What deployable parts exist?	C4 Level 2 Container	Technical leads, ops, security	Structurizr, PlantUML
How is one container structured?	C4 Level 3 Component	Developers	PlantUML, Mermaid
Where does it run?	Deployment diagram	Cloud, ops, security	draw.io
How does data move and where are the trust boundaries?	Data-flow diagram	Security, data protection	draw.io, Threat Dragon
How do these steps interact over time?	Sequence diagram	Developers, integration partners	Mermaid, PlantUML
How is data structured?	Entity-relationship diagram	Developers, DBAs	dbdiagram, draw.io, Mermaid
How is the network segmented?	Network diagram	Network, security, ops	draw.io
What does the client approve?	Presentation deck	Executives	Figma, slides

6. Mandatory Consulting Lifecycle (15 Stages)

Every engagement follows these 15 stages in order. Each stage lists its **procedure, checklist, output, owner, reviewer and approval criteria**. A stage closes only when its approval criteria are met and recorded. Do not start the next stage early; if the client insists, record the risk and get Principal Architect approval.



Gates: no stage starts until the previous stage is approved. Stage 12 is the formal architecture approval.

Figure 6.1 The 15-stage consulting lifecycle in three phases.

Stage	Output	Owner	Reviewer
01 Lead Qualification	Lead qualification record and opportunity assessment	Sales / Project Manager	Principal Architect
02 Discovery	Discovery notes, stakeholder map, open-questions log	Business Analyst	Solution Architect
03 Current-State Assessment	Current-state architecture document and inventories	Junior Technical Analyst (draft) / Solution Architect	Principal Architect
04 Problem Definition	Problem statement and risk/impact summary	Solution Architect	Principal Architect
05 Requirements Definition	Requirements specification (Appendix E)	Business Analyst	Solution Architect + client owner
06 Feasibility Assessment	Technical feasibility report (Appendix F)	Solution Architect	Principal Architect
07 Architecture Alternatives	Options paper and comparison matrix	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

Stage	Output	Owner	Reviewer
08 Target Architecture	Target-state architecture and threat model	Solution Architect with Cloud/Security Architects	Principal Architect
09 Architecture Documentation	Architecture documentation pack	Junior Technical Analyst (draft) / Architects	Principal Architect
10 Cost and Risk Analysis	Cost estimate (Appendix K) and risk register	Solution Architect / Cloud Architect	Project Manager + Principal Architect
11 Client Presentation	Presentation and minutes	Solution Architect	Principal Architect
12 Approval	Signed architecture approval record	Principal Architect	Client sponsor + ARB chair
13 Engineering Handover	Handover pack and acknowledgements	Solution Architect	Engineering leads
14 Architecture Governance	Governance reports and updated ADRs	Software / Solution Architect	Principal Architect / ARB
15 Post-Implementation Review	Post-implementation review report	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

Stage 01 — Lead Qualification

Objective: Decide whether the client is a good fit before spending engineering time.

Procedure

1. Record organisation, industry, size, systems and business objective in the lead form.
2. Hold a 30-minute qualification call with the decision-maker.
3. Check fit with our services, conflicts of interest, budget range and timeline.
4. Score the opportunity (fit, risk, red flags); record unknowns with owners.

Checklist

- [ ] Decision-maker identified
- [ ] Business problem stated in the client's words
- [ ] Budget range and date known or marked unknown
- [ ] Red flags noted (e.g. "guaranteed 100% uptime on a tiny budget")
- [ ] NDA requested if confidential material is shared

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Lead qualification record and opportunity assessment	Sales / Project Manager	Principal Architect

GATE 1: APPROVAL CRITERIA

All fields filled or marked "unknown" with an owner; proceed/decline recorded.

Stage 02 — Discovery

Objective: Learn goals, pain, people and constraints by interviewing stakeholders.

Procedure

1. Agree discovery plan, stakeholder list and interview schedule.
2. Send the questionnaire (Appendix C) in advance.
3. Run interviews and workshops; two people attend (lead + scribe).
4. Collect documents, diagrams, access to non-production systems.
5. Write up notes within 24 hours; confirm facts back to the client.

Checklist

- [ ] All stakeholder groups interviewed
- [ ] Facts tagged CONFIRMED / ASSUMPTION / UNKNOWN
- [ ] Documents received and logged
- [ ] Open questions list with owners and dates
- [ ] Sensitive data handling agreed

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Discovery notes, stakeholder map, open-questions log	Business Analyst	Solution Architect

GATE 2: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Client confirms the discovery summary in writing; every assumption has an owner.

Stage 03 — Current-State Assessment

Objective: Document what exists today: applications, integrations, infrastructure, data, security and operations.

Procedure

1. Inventory applications, owners, technologies, versions and support status.
2. Draw C4 L1/L2 for the as-is system; list integrations and data flows.
3. Document infrastructure, hosting, backup, monitoring and DR as they actually are.
4. Record security posture (access, secrets, patching, logging) factually, without judgement.
5. Capture performance, incident and cost history.

Checklist

- [ ] As-is C4 L1 and L2 drawn and validated by the client

- [ ] Integration list complete
- [ ] Hosting and cost known
- [ ] Backup tested? (yes/no/unknown)
- [ ] Support and licence end dates listed

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Current-state architecture document and inventories	Junior Technical Analyst (draft) / Solution Architect	Principal Architect

GATE 3: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Client technical owner confirms diagrams match reality; gaps flagged.

Stage 04 — Problem Definition

Objective: State the technical limitations, risks, dependencies and business impact.

Procedure

1. Group findings into problems; link each to a business objective.
2. Quantify impact (cost, time, risk) with evidence or marked estimate.
3. Identify root causes, not symptoms.
4. Agree a one-page problem statement with the sponsor.

Checklist

- [ ] Each problem has evidence
- [ ] Business impact stated
- [ ] Dependencies listed
- [ ] Out-of-scope items stated
- [ ] Sponsor has read the statement

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Problem statement and risk/impact summary	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

GATE 4: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Sponsor signs "this is the problem we are solving".

Stage 05 — Requirements Definition

Objective: Document functional and non-functional requirements, constraints and acceptance criteria.

Procedure

1. Derive requirements from objectives and journeys; give each a unique ID.
2. Quantify NFRs (e.g. availability, p95 latency, RPO/RTO, data volume).
3. Separate MUST / SHOULD / COULD; list constraints and assumptions.
4. Write acceptance criteria; build a traceability matrix to objectives.

Checklist

- [ ] Every requirement is testable
- [ ] NFRs have numbers
- [ ] Compliance and data-protection needs stated
- [ ] Traceability matrix complete
- [ ] Priorities agreed

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Requirements specification (Appendix E)	Business Analyst	Solution Architect + client owner

GATE 5: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Client signs requirements baseline; changes follow change control.

Stage 06 — Feasibility Assessment

Objective: Evaluate technology, cost, skills, timeline, compliance and operational feasibility.

Procedure

1. Define feasibility questions from the riskiest requirements.
2. Research options; run small proofs of concept where uncertainty is high.
3. Rate technical, economic, schedule, legal/compliance, operational and skills feasibility.
4. Conclude: feasible / feasible with conditions / not feasible, with evidence.

Checklist

- [ ] Each dimension rated with evidence
- [ ] Spikes timeboxed and recorded
- [ ] Skills gap identified
- [ ] Licence and legal checks done
- [ ] Assumptions listed

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Technical feasibility report (Appendix F)	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

GATE 6: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Conclusion and conditions accepted by sponsor.

Stage 07 — Architecture Alternatives

Objective: Develop at least two viable options (plus "do nothing" baseline) and compare trade-offs.

Procedure

1. Define decision criteria and weights with the client.
2. Design 2-3 viable options at C4 L1/L2.
3. Score options in the technology comparison matrix (Appendix G).
4. Run a sensitivity check: does the winner change if weights change?

Checklist

- [ ] At least two viable options plus baseline
- [ ] Criteria weights agreed before scoring
- [ ] Cost, risk, lock-in and complexity compared
- [ ] Recommendation reasoned, not just highest score
- [ ] Rejected options explained

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Options paper and comparison matrix	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

GATE 7: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Sponsor understands the trade-offs and agrees the preferred option.

Stage 08 — Target Architecture

Objective: Design the recommended solution in enough detail to build, secure and operate.

Procedure

1. Detail the chosen option: containers, components, data, integration, security, deployment, monitoring, DR.
2. Map each requirement to the design element that satisfies it.
3. Threat-model the main data flows.
4. Identify residual risks and open decisions.

Checklist

- [ ] All MUST requirements traced
- [ ] Trust boundaries shown
- [ ] Failure handling and recovery designed

- [ ] Observability designed
- [ ] Open decisions listed with owners

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Target-state architecture and threat model	Solution Architect with Cloud/Security Architects	Principal Architect

GATE 8: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Peer review complete with no unresolved high-severity findings.

Stage 09 — Architecture Documentation

Objective: Produce diagrams, component descriptions, interfaces, data flows and decision records.

Procedure

1. Complete C4 L1-L3, deployment, data-flow and network diagrams.
2. Write component and interface specifications.
3. Write ADRs for every high-impact decision (Appendix D).
4. Assemble in the repository structure (Chapter 7).

Checklist

- [ ] Diagrams consistent with each other
- [ ] Every diagram has title, legend, date, version
- [ ] ADRs numbered and linked
- [ ] Glossary included
- [ ] Docs-as-code merged via reviewed pull request

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Architecture documentation pack	Junior Technical Analyst (draft) / Architects	Principal Architect

GATE 9: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Review checklist (Appendix J) passed.

Stage 10 — Cost and Risk Analysis

Objective: Estimate infrastructure, development, licences, staffing, maintenance and operational risks.

Procedure

1. Estimate build effort by component with ranges (best/likely/worst).
2. Estimate run costs using official cloud calculators; record date and region.

3. Add licences, support, training, and contingency.
4. Build the risk register: likelihood x impact, mitigation, owner.

Checklist

- [ ] One-time and recurring costs separated
- [ ] Currency and tax basis stated
- [ ] Calculator links and dates recorded
- [ ] Contingency justified
- [ ] Top 10 risks have owners

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Cost estimate (Appendix K) and risk register	Solution Architect / Cloud Architect	Project Manager + Principal Architect

GATE 10: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Estimate reviewed by someone who did not prepare it.

Stage 11 — Client Presentation

Objective: Explain the solution and its trade-offs in business language.

Procedure

1. Build the deck from Appendix L: problem, options, recommendation, cost, risk, roadmap, decisions needed.
2. Rehearse with a senior reviewer.
3. Present; capture questions and decisions.
4. Send written follow-up within 24 hours.

Checklist

- [ ] No unexplained jargon
- [ ] Trade-offs shown honestly
- [ ] Decisions needed from the client are explicit
- [ ] Assumptions stated on a slide
- [ ] Appendix of detail available

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Presentation and minutes	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

GATE 11: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Client confirms understanding; objections logged and answered.

Stage 12 — Approval

Objective: Obtain formal architecture approval from the client and our review board.

Procedure

1. Submit the pack to the Architecture Review Board (ARB).
2. Resolve findings; update ADRs.
3. Collect signatures on approval record (client sponsor, our Principal Architect).
4. Baseline the approved version in Git with a tag.

Checklist

- [ ] ARB decision recorded
- [ ] Conditions listed with owners
- [ ] Signatures obtained
- [ ] Version tagged
- [ ] Change process explained

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Signed architecture approval record	Principal Architect	Client sponsor + ARB chair

GATE 12: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Written approval of a specific version; no unresolved critical findings.

Stage 13 — Engineering Handover

Objective: Give development, cloud, data, API and security teams implementation specifications.

Procedure

1. Run the handover workshop per team.
2. Issue specifications, acceptance criteria, environments and standards.
3. Hand over backlog seeds and non-functional test targets.
4. Confirm each team acknowledges scope and open risks.

Checklist

- [ ] Handover checklist (Appendix M) complete
- [ ] Specs linked to requirements
- [ ] Each team has a named contact
- [ ] Definition of done agreed
- [ ] Escalation path defined

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Handover pack and acknowledgements	Solution Architect	Engineering leads

GATE 13: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Each receiving team signs acknowledgement.

Stage 14 — Architecture Governance

Objective: Review implementation against the approved architecture throughout delivery.

Procedure

1. Schedule design reviews at milestones (e.g. after each epic).
2. Check code, infrastructure and pipelines against standards and ADRs.
3. Log deviations; approve, reject or raise a change request.
4. Maintain the technical-debt register.

Checklist

- [ ] Review cadence agreed
- [ ] Deviation log maintained
- [ ] Changes recorded as new/superseding ADRs
- [ ] Debt visible with owners
- [ ] Docs updated with each change

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Governance reports and updated ADRs	Software / Solution Architect	Principal Architect / ARB

GATE 14: APPROVAL CRITERIA

No unapproved deviation remains open at go-live.

Stage 15 — Post-Implementation Review

Objective: Evaluate actual performance, cost, reliability and technical debt after go-live.

Procedure

1. Wait for a meaningful operating period (e.g. 60-90 days).
2. Compare actual vs planned: cost, performance, availability, incidents.
3. Review debt and lessons learned; update templates and standards.
4. Present results; agree improvement actions or a retainer.

Checklist

- [ ] Metrics collected from real monitoring
- [ ] Variances explained
- [ ] Lessons recorded in department knowledge base
- [ ] Debt register updated
- [ ] Client feedback captured

Output	Owner	Reviewer
Post-implementation review report	Solution Architect	Principal Architect

GATE 15: APPROVAL CRITERIA

Report accepted by client; improvements fed back to standards.

7. Architecture Repository Structure

Every engagement uses this structure so any architect can find anything in minutes. Documents are written in Markdown, diagrams as code where possible, changes are reviewed by pull request, and approved baselines are tagged. A ready-made skeleton with placeholder files is supplied in **architecture-project-template/**.

```
architecture-project/
├── README.md
├── docs/
│   ├── executive-summary.md
│   ├── business-context.md
│   ├── requirements/
│   ├── current-state/
│   ├── target-state/
│   ├── constraints.md
│   ├── assumptions.md
│   ├── risks.md
│   ├── architecture-decisions/
│   ├── security/
│   ├── cost-analysis/
│   └── implementation-roadmap.md
├── diagrams/
│   ├── context/        containers/    components/
│   ├── deployment/     data-flow/     network/
├── specifications/
│   ├── api/    database/    integrations/    infrastructure/
├── reviews/
├── adr/
└── handover/
```

Every folder and expected content

Path	Purpose	Expected contents
README.md	Entry point: purpose, status, version, how to navigate, owners, approval state, glossary link.	Project name, client (or code name), version, status, contacts, folder map, how to render diagrams.
docs/executive-summary.md	One-to-two page business summary for executives.	Problem, recommendation, cost range, key risks, decisions needed, next steps. No jargon.
docs/business-context.md	Why the project exists.	Organisation, objectives (measurable), stakeholders, processes, user journeys, success measures.
docs/requirements/	Requirements baseline.	functional.md, non-functional.md, acceptance-criteria.md, traceability.csv; each with unique IDs.
docs/current-state/	As-is architecture.	Application and integration inventory, infrastructure, data, security posture, operations, pain points.

Path	Purpose	Expected contents
docs/target-state/	To-be architecture.	Options paper, chosen architecture narrative, component descriptions, migration strategy, operations model.
docs/constraints.md	Fixed limits.	Budget, dates, skills, legal, technology; each marked CONFIRMED or ASSUMED.
docs/assumptions.md	Unverified beliefs.	ID, statement, impact if wrong, owner, date to confirm, status.
docs/risks.md	Risk register.	ID, description, likelihood, impact, score, mitigation, owner, status.
docs/architecture-decisions/	Narrative of decisions and trade-offs for readers.	Decision summaries linking to ADR files in /adr; comparison matrices.
docs/security/	Security architecture.	Trust boundaries, threat model, control mapping, data classification, access model, open security risks.
docs/cost-analysis/	Money.	Build estimate, run-cost model with calculator references and dates, licences, TCO comparison of options.
docs/implementation-roadmap.md	Delivery plan.	Phases, milestones, dependencies, team needs, rollout and migration plan, review gates.
diagrams/context/	C4 Level 1 diagrams.	Source (.puml / .mmd / .dsl / .drawio) and exported SVG/PNG; one per scenario (as-is, to-be).
diagrams/containers/	C4 Level 2 diagrams.	Deployable units, technologies and protocols.
diagrams/components/	C4 Level 3 diagrams.	Only for containers that need it.
diagrams/deployment/	Where software runs.	Regions, zones, nodes, environments.
diagrams/data-flow/	Data movement and trust boundaries.	DFDs with boundaries, data classes and protocols.
diagrams/network/	Network layout.	Subnets, routing, firewalls, connectivity, DNS.
specifications/api/	API contracts.	OpenAPI / AsyncAPI files, versioning and error policy, auth model.
specifications/database/	Data design.	ERD, data dictionary, migration scripts approach, backup/retention policy.
specifications/integrations/	System-to-system contracts.	Interface catalogue, message formats, retry and error handling, SLAs.
specifications/infrastructure/	Infrastructure design.	Resource list, IaC module structure, environment matrix, sizing assumptions.

Path	Purpose	Expected contents
reviews/	Review evidence.	Peer review records, ARB minutes, checklist results, finding logs with disposition.
adr/	Architecture Decision Records.	0001-title.md … in sequence; status, context, options, decision, consequences. Never deleted, only superseded.
handover/	Engineering handover pack.	Handover checklist, specifications index, environment access process, acknowledgements, open-risk list.

REPOSITORY RULES

One repository per engagement; no secrets or personal data; each document has an owner, version and review date; use pull requests with at least one reviewer; tag the version approved at Stage 12 (for example `arch-approved-v1.0`).

8. Deliverable and Review Standards

Every major consulting project must include the twenty deliverables below. Use the **C4 model** where suitable and make every diagram understandable to technical and non-technical stakeholders: title, legend, scope, date, version, and plain labels (say "Customer database", not "RDS-prod-01").

#	Deliverable	Location	Quality bar
1	Executive summary	docs/executive-summary.md	Business language; recommendation first; max 2 pages
2	Business context	docs/business-context.md	Objectives measurable; stakeholders named
3	Current-state architecture	docs/current-state/ + diagrams	Validated by client
4	Target-state architecture	docs/target-state/ + diagrams	Every MUST requirement traced
5	Functional requirements	docs/requirements/functional.md	IDs, priority, acceptance criteria
6	Non-functional requirements	docs/requirements/non-functional.md	Quantified
7	System context diagram	diagrams/context/	C4 L1; readable by non-technical people
8	Container diagram	diagrams/containers/	C4 L2; technologies and protocols labelled
9	Component diagram	diagrams/components/	C4 L3 for key containers
10	Deployment diagram	diagrams/deployment/	Environments, zones, redundancy
11	Data flow diagram	diagrams/data-flow/	Data classes and trust boundaries
12	Integration diagram	specifications/integrations/	Every interface with owner and protocol
13	Security and trust boundaries	docs/security/	Threat model and control mapping
14	Technology selection matrix	docs/architecture-decisions/	Weights agreed before scoring
15	Architecture Decision Records	adr/	One per high-impact decision
16	Risk register	docs/risks.md	Owners and mitigations
17	Cost estimate	docs/cost-analysis/	Ranges, sources, dates
18	Implementation roadmap	docs/implementation-roadmap.md	Phases and gates
19	Migration strategy	docs/target-state/migration.md	Cut-over, rollback, data migration, parallel run

#	Deliverable	Location	Quality bar
20	Operational considerations	docs/target-state/operations.md	Monitoring, backup, DR, support, runbooks

Diagram standards

- One diagram, one purpose, one audience. If it needs more than ~12 boxes, split it.
- Every element has a name, a type, and a short description; every arrow has a label saying what flows and how.
- Always include a legend and the C4 level; show system boundary and trust boundaries.
- Colour is never the only carrier of meaning (accessibility); keep a consistent palette.
- Store diagram source in Git next to exported images.

Architecture review standards

Review area	Key questions	Pass criteria
Requirement coverage	Is every MUST requirement traced to a design element?	Traceability 100% for MUST
Architecture consistency	Do diagrams, ADRs and specs agree?	No contradictions
Security boundaries	Are trust boundaries, authN/authZ and secrets handled?	Threat model reviewed; no open high risk
Data protection	Data classified, encrypted, retained and deleted per policy and law?	Controls mapped; privacy owner consulted
Scalability	What breaks first at 10x?	Bottleneck and plan documented
Availability	Single points of failure? Meets target?	SPOFs removed or accepted in writing
Failure handling	Timeouts, retries, idempotency, degradation?	Designed per integration
Observability	Can we detect and diagnose problems?	Logs, metrics, traces, alerts defined
Backup and recovery	RPO/RTO defined and restore tested?	Test plan exists
Performance	Targets and test plan?	Numeric targets
Operational complexity	Can the client run it?	Skills gap closed or planned
Cost	Estimate reproducible with sources?	Independent review done
Maintainability	Is change cheap?	Boundaries and tests in place
Vendor dependency	Lock-in understood with an exit plan?	Documented

Review area	Key questions	Pass criteria
Implementation feasibility	Can the team build it in time?	Plan and skills validated

ASSUMPTIONS AND UNRESOLVED DECISIONS

Every deliverable has an **Assumptions** and an **Unresolved decisions** section. Mark each fact as CONFIRMED (with source), ASSUMED (with owner and confirm-by date) or UNKNOWN. **Never present an unverified assumption as a confirmed client fact.**

9. Commercial Costing and Pricing

ILLUSTRATIVE NUMBERS

All rates, hours and margins below are **training defaults in Indian rupees (Rs), excluding GST**. They demonstrate the method. Finance and the Principal Architect must approve real rates before any quote is issued.

Cost components to estimate on every engagement

Component	How to estimate	Common mistake
Discovery workshops	Sessions x people x hours + preparation (about 1:1) + write-up	Forgetting preparation and write-up
Business analysis	Requirements count x hours each; interviews x hours	Underestimating review cycles
Technical assessment	Systems x hours per system (inventory, review, interview)	Assuming documents exist
Architecture design	Components x hours; options x hours; ADRs x 2-4 h	Designing only one option
Architecture reviews	Review rounds x reviewer hours	No time for rework after review
Security architecture review	Data flows x threat-model hours + control mapping	Treating it as a checkbox
Cloud cost estimation	Official calculator; region, size, hours, data transfer; record date	Ignoring data transfer, backups, support plans
Documentation	Pages x hours; diagrams x hours	Leaving it to the end
Stakeholder presentations	Preparation + rehearsal + delivery + follow-up	No rehearsal
Implementation support	Review milestones x hours + on-call Q&A	Open-ended unpaid support
Travel / workshop expenses	Actual receipts or fixed allowance in the SOW	Not agreeing who pays
Ongoing advisory retainer	Fixed monthly hours; rollover rules; response times	No cap on out-of-hours requests

Rate card (internal, illustrative)

Role	Loaded cost per hour	Standard billing rate per hour
Junior Technical Analyst	Rs 450	Rs 1,200

Role	Loaded cost per hour	Standard billing rate per hour
Business Analyst	Rs 700	Rs 1,800
Solution Architect	Rs 1,200	Rs 3,200
Cloud Architect	Rs 1,300	Rs 3,500
Security Architect	Rs 1,400	Rs 3,800
Principal Architect	Rs 2,000	Rs 5,500
Project Manager	Rs 900	Rs 2,200

Loaded cost = salary + statutory benefits + equipment, licences, space and a share of management overhead, divided by realistic billable hours (not 2,080).

Definitions and formulas

Term	Formula	Meaning
Delivery cost (DC)	Σ(hours x loaded cost) + direct expenses	What it costs us to deliver
Risk reserve (RR)	Risk % x DC	Money set aside for estimating error; embedded in price
Selling price	Round-up((DC + RR) / (1 − target gross margin))	Quoted fee (ex GST)
Gross margin %	(Price − DC) / Price	Profit after direct delivery costs
Contribution margin	Price − DC − variable selling costs (4%) − RR	What remains to cover fixed overhead and profit; reserve assumed fully used (conservative)
Overrun stress test	(Price − 1.25 x DC) / Price	Gross margin if effort overruns by 25%
Recurring revenue	MRR = monthly fee; ARR = 12 x MRR	Predictable income; basis for valuing the practice

A. Fixed-scope architecture assessment

3 weeks; current-state review, findings, options, roadmap.

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Junior Technical Analyst	80	Rs 450	Rs 36,000
Business Analyst	40	Rs 700	Rs 28,000
Solution Architect	60	Rs 1,200	Rs 72,000

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Cloud Architect	16	Rs 1,300	Rs 20,800
Security Architect	16	Rs 1,400	Rs 22,400
Principal Architect	12	Rs 2,000	Rs 24,000
Project Manager	16	Rs 900	Rs 14,400
Total labour	**240**		**Rs 2,17,600**
Workshop / travel			Rs 12,000
Tools and licences			Rs 3,000

Metric	Value
Delivery cost (DC)	Rs 2,32,600
Risk reserve (10% of DC)	Rs 23,260
Selling price (ex GST)	**Rs 5,12,000**
Gross profit	Rs 2,79,400
Gross margin	**54.6%**
Variable selling costs (4%)	Rs 20,480
Contribution margin	Rs 2,35,660 (46.0%)
Blended rate per hour	Rs 2,133
Discount vs standard rate card (negative = premium)	11.4% (standard value Rs 5,78,000)
Stress test: gross margin at +25% effort	43.2%

B. Architecture design engagement

8 weeks; full lifecycle stages 02-12 with documentation and presentation.

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Junior Technical Analyst	240	Rs 450	Rs 1,08,000
Business Analyst	120	Rs 700	Rs 84,000
Solution Architect	200	Rs 1,200	Rs 2,40,000
Cloud Architect	60	Rs 1,300	Rs 78,000

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Security Architect	60	Rs 1,400	Rs 84,000
Principal Architect	40	Rs 2,000	Rs 80,000
Project Manager	48	Rs 900	Rs 43,200
Total labour	**768**		**Rs 7,17,200**
Workshop / travel			Rs 30,000
Tools, calculators, licences			Rs 6,000

Metric	Value
Delivery cost (DC)	Rs 7,53,200
Risk reserve (12% of DC)	Rs 90,384
Selling price (ex GST)	**Rs 16,88,000**
Gross profit	Rs 9,34,800
Gross margin	**55.4%**
Variable selling costs (4%)	Rs 67,520
Contribution margin	Rs 7,76,896 (46.0%)
Blended rate per hour	Rs 2,198
Discount vs standard rate card (negative = premium)	11.5% (standard value Rs 19,07,600)
Stress test: gross margin at +25% effort	44.2%

C. Technical due diligence

4 weeks; independent assessment for an investor or acquirer; fixed deadline.

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Junior Technical Analyst	60	Rs 450	Rs 27,000
Business Analyst	20	Rs 700	Rs 14,000
Solution Architect	80	Rs 1,200	Rs 96,000
Cloud Architect	24	Rs 1,300	Rs 31,200
Security Architect	40	Rs 1,400	Rs 56,000

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Principal Architect	40	Rs 2,000	Rs 80,000
Project Manager	20	Rs 900	Rs 18,000
Total labour	**284**		**Rs 3,22,200**
Travel / data-room access			Rs 10,000
Tools (code and dependency scanning)			Rs 5,000

Metric	Value
Delivery cost (DC)	Rs 3,37,200
Risk reserve (15% of DC)	Rs 50,580
Selling price (ex GST)	**Rs 9,70,000**
Gross profit	Rs 6,32,800
Gross margin	**65.2%**
Variable selling costs (4%)	Rs 38,800
Contribution margin	Rs 5,43,420 (56.0%)
Blended rate per hour	Rs 3,415
Discount vs standard rate card (negative = premium)	-12.3% (standard value Rs 8,64,000)
Stress test: gross margin at +25% effort	56.5%

D. Implementation advisory

12 weeks; governance reviews, design Q&A, compliance checks.

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Junior Technical Analyst	60	Rs 450	Rs 27,000
Solution Architect	144	Rs 1,200	Rs 1,72,800
Security Architect	12	Rs 1,400	Rs 16,800
Principal Architect	24	Rs 2,000	Rs 48,000
Project Manager	24	Rs 900	Rs 21,600
Total labour	**264**		**Rs 2,86,200**

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Travel / workshops			Rs 8,000

Metric	Value
Delivery cost (DC)	Rs 2,94,200
Risk reserve (8% of DC)	Rs 23,536
Selling price (ex GST)	**Rs 6,36,000**
Gross profit	Rs 3,41,800
Gross margin	**53.7%**
Variable selling costs (4%)	Rs 25,440
Contribution margin	Rs 2,92,824 (46.0%)
Blended rate per hour	Rs 2,409
Discount vs standard rate card (negative = premium)	16.7% (standard value Rs 7,63,200)
Stress test: gross margin at +25% effort	42.2%

E. Monthly architecture consulting (retainer)

Per month; fixed hours of advice, reviews, ADR support.

Role / expense	Hours	Cost per hour	Cost
Junior Technical Analyst	16	Rs 450	Rs 7,200
Solution Architect	24	Rs 1,200	Rs 28,800
Principal Architect	6	Rs 2,000	Rs 12,000
Project Manager	4	Rs 900	Rs 3,600
Total labour	**50**		**Rs 51,600**
Tools and admin			Rs 1,500

Metric	Value
Delivery cost (DC)	Rs 53,100
Risk reserve (5% of DC)	Rs 2,655
Selling price (ex GST)	**Rs 1,02,000**

Metric	Value
Gross profit	Rs 48,900
Gross margin	**47.9%**
Variable selling costs (4%)	Rs 4,080
Contribution margin	Rs 42,165 (41.3%)
Blended rate per hour	Rs 2,040
Discount vs standard rate card (negative = premium)	26.0% (standard value Rs 1,37,800)
Stress test: gross margin at +25% effort	34.9%

Recurring revenue (retainer)

Metric	Value
Monthly fee (MRR)	Rs 1,02,000
Annual recurring revenue (ARR)	Rs 12,24,000
Annual gross profit at current margin	Rs 5,86,800
Annual delivery cost	Rs 6,37,200

Pipeline logic: if 30% of design engagements (Model B, price Rs 16,88,000) convert to retainers (an *assumption* to measure, not a promise), ten design engagements per year would add about Rs 36,72,000 of ARR after conversion. Track the actual conversion rate and replace this assumption.

Project risk scoring for fixed-price quotes

Risk factor	Low (1)	Medium (2)	High (3)
Requirement clarity	Signed requirements	Partly known	Vague
Client access to people/data	Named and available	Limited	Unknown
Technology novelty	Familiar	Some new	Mostly new
Stakeholder alignment	Single sponsor	Several, aligned	Conflicting
Deadline pressure	Flexible	Firm	Immovable

Total 5-7 → reserve 5-8% · 8-11 → 10-12% · 12-15 → 15-20% **or** quote time-and-materials. Never absorb unlimited risk in a fixed price.

PRICING RULES

1) Price on value and risk, not only on hours. 2) Put scope, assumptions, exclusions and change control in the SOW. 3) Cloud run-costs are estimates from official calculators, shown as ranges with dates; we do not guarantee client cloud bills. 4) Discounts above 10% need Principal Architect and Finance approval. 5) GST and taxes are added as applicable; confirm with Finance.

10. Beginner Onboarding Guide

Welcome to the Software Architecture & Technical Consulting Department. This guide takes you from your first day to your first reviewed architecture diagram.

What this department is (and is not)

- **We are** advisers who help clients make sound, explainable technology decisions.
- **We are not** diagram factories. A diagram without a decision, a reason and a requirement behind it has no value.
- **You are** supported: seniors review everything you produce, and mistakes found in review are learning, not failure.

Before day 1 (manager checklist)

- [ ] Laptop, company email, GitHub organisation access (least privilege), VS Code installed
- [ ] Password manager and multi-factor authentication enabled
- [ ] Read confidentiality and acceptable-use policies; sign acknowledgement
- [ ] Assign a mentor (Solution Architect) and a reviewer (Principal Architect)
- [ ] Create the trainee's training repository from architecture-project-template/

First week plan

Day	Learn	Do	Output	Sign-off
1	Department purpose; golden rules; how a project flows (Chapter 6)	Tool setup; clone the template repo; read the 15 stages	Setup checklist signed; 1-paragraph summary of the lifecycle in own words	Mentor
2	Level 1: software, servers, networks, APIs	Call a public API in Postman; trace DNS	Notes + screenshots in /reviews/week1	Mentor
3	Level 1: databases, cloud, security basics	Explain IaaS/PaaS/SaaS with examples	One-page explainer	Mentor
4	Layered architecture; three-tier	Lesson L-02: draw first diagram (Chapter 11)	Diagram v1	Mentor
5	Review and feedback	Revise diagram; write 5 lessons learned	Diagram v2 + review record	Principal / Solution Architect

Daily working rhythm

1. Morning: read your mentor's notes and today's learning objective.

2. Study and practise (about 50% of time in first 30 days).
3. Produce one written artefact per day (note, diagram, ADR draft).
4. Commit work to Git with a clear message; open a pull request for review.
5. End of day: write three lines: done, blocked, next.

How to ask for help

- Try for 20-30 minutes; write down what you tried and what you expected.
- Ask your mentor with that note. Questions with context get answers in minutes.
- Never guess a client fact. Mark it ASSUMPTION and ask.

PROFESSIONAL CONDUCT

Client information is confidential. Never paste client data into public tools. Never store secrets in Git. Never email client documents to personal accounts. Report mistakes immediately: speed matters more than blame.

Your first 30-60-90 days at a glance

Period	Goal	Evidence
Days 1-30	Understand fundamentals and business analysis; produce first diagrams	Levels 1-2 passed; Projects 1-2 reviewed
Days 31-60	Architecture fundamentals, patterns, technical architecture	Levels 3-5 passed; Projects 3-6 reviewed
Days 61-90	Evaluation, governance and a full simulated proposal	Levels 6-7 passed; Projects 7-9 reviewed; supervised shadowing of a real engagement

11. First Architecture Diagram Exercise

Objective: draw a clear **three-tier application architecture** for a simulated client, then create the matching **C4 Level 1 system context diagram**. You will use draw.io (visual) and Mermaid or PlantUML (diagram-as-code).

> **SIMULATED CLIENT (FICTIONAL)**
>
> **GreenLeaf Organics** sells organic produce. Today orders arrive by phone and WhatsApp and are written into a spreadsheet. The owner wants customers to order online, pay by card, and receive confirmation by SMS/email. Store staff must see and update orders and stock. Accounting uses an existing package. Expected: 200 concurrent users at peak (ASSUMED). Budget and date: unknown.

Step-by-step

1. **Read the brief twice.** Underline actors (customer, staff) and external systems (payment gateway, SMS/email, accounting).
2. **List 8 requirements** (4 functional, 4 non-functional with numbers). Mark each CONFIRMED, ASSUMED or UNKNOWN. In this brief, almost all are ASSUMED.
3. **Open draw.io** and create a new diagram. Name the file `greenleaf-three-tier-v1.drawio`; save it in `diagrams/containers/`.
4. **Draw three columns/boxes:** Presentation (web UI in the browser), Application (business logic and API on servers), Data (SQL database). Label each with its technology only if justified; otherwise label the role.
5. **Draw arrows** with labels: HTTPS, JSON/REST, SQL. Arrows go only between neighbouring tiers.
6. **Draw the network boundary** around everything except the customer. Add a legend and a title with the date and version.
7. **Check:** can the browser reach the database directly? It must not.
8. **Export** SVG and PNG next to the source file. Commit with the message `docs: add three-tier diagram v1`.
9. **Draw the C4 Level 1 context diagram** (next page): one box for the system, people and external systems around it, labelled relationships.
10. **Write the one-paragraph explanation** a non-technical owner can understand, plus 3 assumptions and 3 open questions.
11. **Submit** a pull request to your mentor.

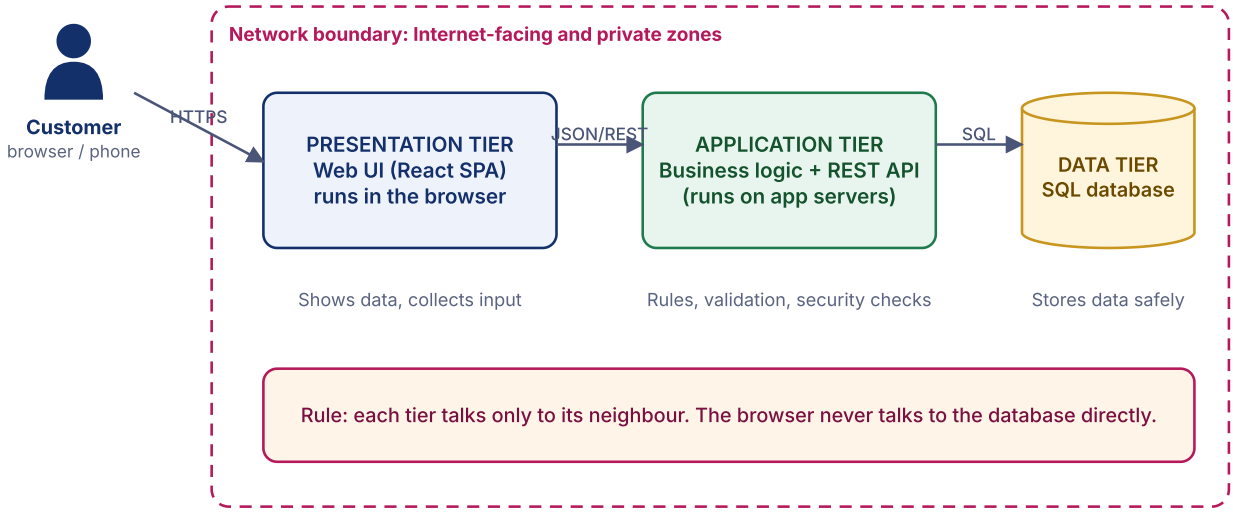


Figure 11.1 Answer key: three-tier architecture for GreenLeaf Organics (training example).

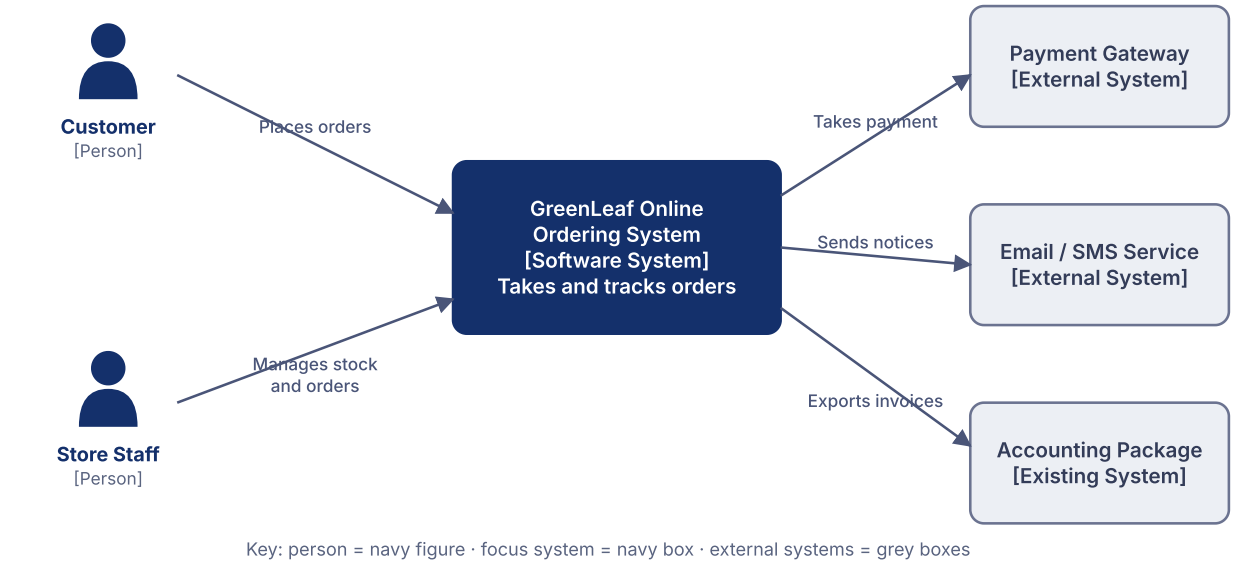


Figure 11.2 Answer key: C4 Level 1 system context (training example).

PlantUML version of the same context diagram

```
@startuml
!include https://raw.githubusercontent.com/plantuml-stdlib/C4-PlantUML/master/C4_Context.puml
title System Context: GreenLeaf Online Ordering (FICTIONAL EXAMPLE)
Person(customer, "Customer", "Buys organic produce online")
Person(staff, "Store Staff", "Manages stock and orders")
System(sys, "GreenLeaf Online Ordering System", "Takes and tracks orders")
System_Ext(pay, "Payment Gateway", "Card payments")
System_Ext(msg, "Email / SMS Service", "Customer notices")
System_Ext(acc, "Accounting Package", "Existing finance system")
```

```
Rel(customer, sys, "Places orders", "HTTPS")
Rel(staff, sys, "Manages stock and orders", "HTTPS")
Rel(sys, pay, "Takes payment", "HTTPS/API")
Rel(sys, msg, "Sends notices", "HTTPS/API")
Rel(sys, acc, "Exports invoices", "File/API")
@enduml
```

RENDERING

Paste the Mermaid source into any Mermaid renderer or a GitHub Markdown code block tagged `mermaid`. For PlantUML use the VS Code PlantUML extension. Check the official sites (Chapter 14) for current syntax and the C4-PlantUML include path.

Marking rubric (100 marks)

Criterion	Marks	Full marks when
Correct tiers and responsibilities	20	Three tiers present with correct roles
Correct dependencies	15	Only neighbour-to-neighbour; no browser-to-database arrow
Labels and protocols	15	Every arrow labelled with what flows and how
Boundaries and legend	10	Network/trust boundary, legend, title, date, version
C4 context correctness	20	Actors, system, external systems, relationships, no internal detail
Plain-language explanation	10	Owner could understand it; no unexplained jargon
Assumptions and open questions	10	Honest labelling; none presented as fact

Pass mark: 75. Below 75: revise and resubmit once. The reviewer records feedback in `reviews/`.

Common mistakes in this exercise

- Naming products (e.g. "MongoDB") before any requirement justifies them.
- Drawing every possible box. A context diagram should have fewer than 10.
- Arrows with no label or no direction.
- Mixing levels: a database table in a context diagram.
- Treating assumptions as facts.

12. Teaching Lessons (15-Part Format)

Every subject in the syllabus is taught with these fifteen parts. The first five lessons below are complete; trainers create the others with the same template (Appendix A).

L-01 Software Architecture vs Design

1 Definition	Architecture is the set of significant decisions about a system's structure, qualities and constraints that are costly to change. Design is the detailed work inside those decisions.
2 Business relevance	Architecture decisions decide long-term cost, speed of change, risk and scalability. Mistakes are expensive after release.
3 Technical purpose	To ensure the system meets functional and quality requirements and can evolve, by choosing structure, technologies and boundaries deliberately.
4 Real-world case	A retailer chose one shared database for everything. Three years later, a reporting query slowed checkout during sales. Changing it needed a rebuild: an architectural, not a coding, mistake.
5 Prerequisites	Level 1 complete. Basic understanding of client/server and databases.
6 Tools	Notebook, draw.io, Markdown in VS Code.
7 Step-by-step method	1) List the decisions in a sample system. 2) For each, ask: how costly to reverse? 3) Costly or cross-cutting = architectural. 4) Record architectural ones as ADRs; leave the rest to design.
8 Diagram	Draw a "cost of change" curve: low early, high late. Mark where architectural decisions sit.
9 Decision trade-offs	Too much architecture up front wastes effort and guesses; too little causes rework. Decide the minimum needed to proceed safely (the "last responsible moment").
10 Expected output	A table of 10 decisions classified architectural/design with reasons.
11 Verification	Mentor picks 3 items and asks "why architectural?" The trainee answers using cost-of-reversal and impact.
12 Common mistakes	Calling every technology choice architecture; ignoring quality attributes; confusing diagrams with architecture.
13 Documentation	Table stored in /reviews/week2/classification.md; architectural items linked to draft ADRs.
14 Assignment	Classify decisions from the GreenLeaf case (database, hosting, UI library, button colour, payment provider, password rules...).
15 Review and approval	Reviewer: Solution Architect. Approved when at least 8/10 are classified correctly with sound reasons.

L-02 Three-Tier Architecture (first diagram)

1 **Definition**	A layered style splitting an application into presentation, application (business logic) and data tiers, each deployable and replaceable independently.
2 **Business relevance**	The default shape of most business web applications; easy to staff, secure and maintain; gives a base to scale from.
3 **Technical purpose**	Separation of concerns, security (data tier is not exposed), independent scaling per tier, testability.
4 **Real-world case**	GreenLeaf's online ordering: browser UI, an API with pricing and stock rules, and a SQL database.
5 **Prerequisites**	Level 1; client/server; HTTP; databases.
6 **Tools**	draw.io, Mermaid, VS Code, Git.
7 **Step-by-step method**	Follow the 11 steps in Chapter 11.
8 **Diagram**	Figure 11.1.
9 **Decision trade-offs**	Simple and well understood, but the business tier can become a bottleneck or "ball of mud"; for very large systems consider modular or service-based styles.
10 **Expected output**	greenleaf-three-tier-v1.drawio plus SVG/PNG exports and a one-paragraph explanation.
11 **Verification**	Rubric score of at least 75; reviewer can trace every arrow to a requirement.
12 **Common mistakes**	Browser-to-database arrow; no labels; technology names without reasons; missing boundary.
13 **Documentation**	Files in diagrams/containers/; explanation in docs/target-state/overview.md.
14 **Assignment**	Redraw for a different client (clinic appointment booking) and list two risks of your design.
15 **Review and approval**	Reviewer: mentor. Final: Principal Architect samples 1 in 3 diagrams.

L-03 C4 Model: System Context Diagram

1 **Definition**	C4 describes software at four zoom levels: Context, Containers, Components, Code. Level 1 shows the system as one box with its users and neighbouring systems.
2 **Business relevance**	Gives executives and engineers one shared picture; exposes scope and external dependencies early.

3 Technical purpose	Establishes the system boundary and external interfaces before design detail.
4 Real-world case	On a bank project, the context diagram revealed an unmentioned legacy mainframe feed: a hidden dependency found in week 1, not at go-live.
5 Prerequisites	L-01, L-02; stakeholders and external systems concepts.
6 Tools	Structurizr DSL, PlantUML (C4), Mermaid, draw.io.
7 Step-by-step method	1) Name the system and one-line purpose. 2) List people (roles, not names). 3) List external systems. 4) Draw relationships with verbs ("Places orders"). 5) Add legend and title. 6) Remove anything that is inside the system.
8 Diagram	Figure 11.2.
9 Decision trade-offs	What to show vs hide: include only what helps decide scope. More detail belongs in Level 2.
10 Expected output	One-page context diagram with legend, plus an interface list (name, direction, owner).
11 Verification	Client can say "yes, that is our world". Every external system has an owner and a contact.
12 Common mistakes	Mixing levels; unlabeled arrows; showing technologies at Level 1; omitting existing systems.
13 Documentation	diagrams/context/ source and export; interface list in specifications/integrations/.
14 Assignment	Create context diagrams for as-is and to-be GreenLeaf systems.
15 Review and approval	Reviewer: Solution Architect; client technical owner confirms.

L-04 Non-Functional Requirements

1 Definition	Requirements describing how well the system performs: performance, availability, security, scalability, maintainability and more.
2 Business relevance	Customers judge by speed and reliability; failures cost revenue and trust.
3 Technical purpose	NFRs are the main drivers of architectural choices (redundancy, caching, security controls).
4 Real-world case	Requirement "fast" became "95% of checkout requests complete in under 800 ms at 200 concurrent users", which justified caching and a managed database tier.
5 Prerequisites	Level 2 first half.

6 **Tools**	Requirements template (Appendix E), spreadsheet, load-test calculators.
7 **Step-by-step method**	1) For each quality attribute ask the stakeholder a concrete question. 2) Convert answers to numbers and conditions. 3) Mark CONFIRMED/ASSUMED. 4) Record the measurement method. 5) Agree priority.
8 **Diagram**	Quality-attribute utility tree (attribute → scenario → measure).
9 **Decision trade-offs**	Higher availability and lower latency cost more; ask the client to choose with prices shown.
10 **Expected output**	NFR table with ID, statement, measure, target, source, status.
11 **Verification**	Every NFR can be tested. A tester could write a pass/fail test from it.
12 **Common mistakes**	Words like "fast", "secure", "user-friendly" with no numbers; copying 99.99% without cost discussion.
13 **Documentation**	docs/requirements/non-functional.md.
14 **Assignment**	Write 12 NFRs for GreenLeaf, covering at least 8 quality attributes.
15 **Review and approval**	Reviewer: Business Analyst + Solution Architect.

L-05 Architecture Decision Records

1 **Definition**	A short, dated document recording one significant decision: context, options, decision and consequences.
2 **Business relevance**	Preserves why we decided, avoids repeating debates and supports audits and due diligence.
3 **Technical purpose**	Makes trade-offs explicit and reviewable; links decisions to requirements.
4 **Real-world case**	A team later wanted to replace the database. The ADR showed the original constraint had vanished, so the change was approved in a day.
5 **Prerequisites**	L-01.
6 **Tools**	Markdown, Git, ADR template (Appendix D).
7 **Step-by-step method**	1) Write the problem and constraints. 2) List 2-3 real options. 3) State the decision in one sentence. 4) Write good and bad consequences. 5) Set status Proposed. 6) Get review; set Accepted. 7) Never edit; supersede.
8 **Diagram**	Figure 12.1 (ADR status lifecycle).

9 **Decision trade-offs**	More ADRs = more overhead. Write one only for high-impact or hard-to-reverse decisions.
10 **Expected output**	ADR-0001 in /adr using the template.
11 **Verification**	A new team member can understand the decision without asking the author.
12 **Common mistakes**	Only one option listed; hiding downsides; justifying with fashion; editing accepted ADRs.
13 **Documentation**	adr/0001-title.md, linked from docs/architecture-decisions/.
14 **Assignment**	Write ADR for "monolith vs microservices" for GreenLeaf (use the example below as a model, not a copy).
15 **Review and approval**	Reviewer: Software Architect; approver for high-impact: Principal Architect.

Worked example: Architecture Decision Record

```
# ADR-0003: Start with a modular monolith on managed PostgreSQL

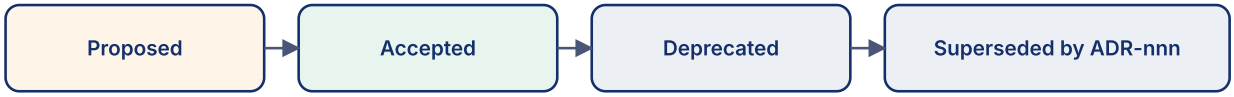
Status: Proposed   | Date: 2026-11-04 | Deciders: Solution Architect (author), Principal Architect
(approver)
Reviewer: <name>   | Supersedes: none

## Context
GreenLeaf has a 4-person development team (CONFIRMED, interview 2026-10-28), no on-call
experience (CONFIRMED), expects 200 concurrent users at peak (ASSUMED, owner: client CFO, confirm by
2026-11-15).

## Options considered
1. Modular monolith + managed PostgreSQL   2. Microservices on Kubernetes   3. Low-code SaaS storefront

## Decision
We will build a modular monolith with a single managed PostgreSQL database.

## Consequences
+ Lowest operational burden; single deployment; fastest delivery (est. 10 weeks).
+ Strong transactions for orders and stock.
- Whole application scales together; revisit if any module needs independent scaling.
- Module boundaries need enforcement (architecture tests).
Review trigger: peak concurrency > 1,000 or team > 15 engineers.
```



ADRs are immutable once accepted: change a decision by writing a NEW ADR that supersedes it.

Figure 12.1 ADR status lifecycle. Accepted ADRs are never edited, only superseded.

13. Practical Training Projects

Nine projects, each reviewed by a senior and signed in the trainee log. Use fictional or fully anonymised clients only.

#	Project	Deliverable	Acceptance
1	Basic three-tier application	Diagram + 1-paragraph explanation	Rubric in Chapter 11 ≥ 75
2	C4 system context diagram	Context diagram + interface list	Actors/systems complete; owner confirms
3	Database architecture	ERD, data dictionary, backup and retention plan, RPO/RTO	Normalised; keys defined; restore test described
4	Monolith vs microservices	Comparison matrix + recommendation + ADR	Criteria weighted before scoring; trade-offs honest
5	REST API architecture	OpenAPI skeleton, versioning, auth, error model, rate limit policy	Valid OpenAPI; consistent naming; secured
6	Cloud-hosted application	Deployment + network diagram, cost range with calculator date, DR plan	No single point of failure unaccepted; costs sourced
7	Architecture Decision Record	Complete ADR with 2+ options	Reviewer can understand it cold
8	Technical feasibility assessment	Report (Appendix F) with conclusion and conditions	Evidence per dimension; assumptions labelled
9	Full architecture proposal for a simulated client	Repository with all 20 deliverables (Chapter 8) + 20-minute presentation	ARB-style review passed

Project 9 assessment: full proposal

Area	Weight
Requirements quality and traceability	15%
Options and decision quality	20%
Target architecture and diagrams	20%
Security and operations	15%
Cost and risk analysis	10%
Documentation and repository hygiene	10%
Presentation in business language	10%

CERTIFICATION OF COMPETENCE

Completion of the nine projects plus Levels 1-7 qualifies the trainee as **Junior Technical Analyst (cleared)**. Promotion to Solution Architect additionally needs two supervised real engagements and a Principal Architect sign-off.

90-Day Training Roadmap

Thirteen weeks, one gate every four weeks. Study about 50% and practise about 50% in the first month; move toward supervised real work in the last month.

Week	Focus	Deliverable	Assessment / gate
1	Onboarding, tools, lifecycle overview	Setup done; first diagram started	Setup checklist
2	Level 1: software, networks, cloud, security basics	Notes; Postman collection; DNS trace	Oral quiz
3	Level 2: stakeholders, interviews, objectives	Stakeholder map; mock interview	Mentor review
4	Level 2: requirements, NFRs, acceptance, risks	Requirements for GreenLeaf	Project 1-2 reviewed; Gate: Levels 1-2
5	Level 3: architecture vs design; components; coupling	Classification table	Mentor review
6	Level 3: layered, modular monolith, microservices, events	Project 4 draft	Peer review
7	Level 4: patterns (Chapter 4)	Pattern "when NOT to use" notes	Quiz
8	Level 4 continued; ADRs	Project 7 (ADR)	Gate: Levels 3-4
9	Level 5: application, database, API	Projects 3 and 5	Review
10	Level 5: cloud, network, security, DR	Project 6	Security Architect review
11	Level 6: evaluation; cost; feasibility	Project 8	Gate: Levels 5-6
12	Level 7: governance; shadow a real engagement	Governance notes; shadow log	Mentor
13	Capstone: Project 9 proposal and presentation	Full proposal	ARB-style panel; final sign-off

Scorecard

Dimension	Evidence	Rating (1-5)
Fundamentals	Quizzes, notes	
Analysis quality	Requirements, interview write-ups	
Design reasoning	Options, ADRs	

Dimension	Evidence	Rating (1-5)
Diagrams	Clarity and correctness	
Communication	Presentation, emails	
Professionalism	Honesty about assumptions, confidentiality	

VEL SOFTWARE SOLUTIONS

14. Official Learning Sources and Standards

These are the **official sources** for this curriculum. Click each to open. Use them as the authority over this handbook when they differ.

LINK VERIFICATION STATUS

The build environment blocked outbound requests to these sites, so the links could **not** be machine-checked on the build date (4 Nov 2026). They are the official domains supplied in the brief. Run `check-links.sh` from the package (or open each link) and record the date and result in the table before relying on it.

Source	Link	Use in this curriculum	Access / cost	Checked (date, initials)
C4 model	c4model.com/	Notation and guidance for software architecture diagrams (Simon Brown)	Free	____
Martin Fowler: Architecture	martinfowler.com/architecture/	Essays and patterns on software architecture	Free	____
The Open Group: TOGAF	www.opengroup.org/togaf	Enterprise architecture framework; certification	Reading free; certification paid; commercial use may need licence	____
ISO	www.iso.org/	Catalogue of ISO standards (e.g. ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010, ISO/IEC 25010, ISO/IEC 27001)	Standards are paid	____
Azure Architecture Center	learn.microsoft.com/azure/architecture/	Patterns, reference architectures, Well-Architected guidance	Free	____
AWS Well-Architected	docs.aws.amazon.com/wellarchitected/	Framework pillars and review questions	Free	____
Google Cloud Architecture Framework	cloud.google.com/architecture/framework	Google Cloud design principles and pillars	Free	____
OWASP	owasp.org/	Application security: Top 10, ASVS, cheat sheets, Threat Dragon	Free, open	____

Source	Link	Use in this curriculum	Access / cost	Checked (date, initials)
NIST Cybersecurity Framework	www.nist.gov/cyberframework	Cybersecurity risk framework (CSF 2.0 published 2024; verify edition)	Free	____
UML	www.uml.org/	OMG Unified Modeling Language information	Specs free from OMG	____
PlantUML	plantuml.com/	Diagram-as-code reference	Open source (check edition)	____
Mermaid	mermaid.js.org/	Diagram-as-code in Markdown	Open source	____
draw.io (diagrams.net)	www.drawio.com/	Visual diagram editor	Free	____

Additional recommended references

Source	Link	Use
ADR GitHub organisation	adr.github.io/	Architecture Decision Record practice and templates
arc42	arc42.org/	Architecture documentation template
Structurizr documentation	docs.structurizr.com/	Structurizr DSL and Lite
Terraform documentation	developer.hashicorp.com/terraform/docs	Infrastructure as code
Postman Learning Center	learning.postman.com/	API tooling
OWASP Threat Dragon	owasp.org/www-project-threat-dragon/	Open source threat modelling
Microsoft Threat Modeling Tool	learn.microsoft.com/azure/security/develop/threat-modeling-tool	STRIDE-based modelling tool
OpenAPI Specification	spec.openapis.org/oas/latest.html	REST API contract standard
Google SRE books	sre.google/books/	Reliability and operations practice
The Twelve-Factor App	12factor.net/	Cloud-native application principles

Frameworks and standards: status, relevance and when a licence or certification is required

Item	Status and relevance (verify current edition)	Licence or certification needed?
C4 model	Stable, widely used; method not a standard.	No.
TOGAF Standard	The 10th Edition (2022) is current at last knowledge; relevant for enterprise architecture work. Certification structure changed after 9.2: check the Open Group certification portfolio.	Reading free. Personal certification is optional and paid via The Open Group. Using TOGAF as the basis of commercial products or training may need a licence: confirm on opengroup.org.
ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010	International standard for architecture description (current edition 2022 at last knowledge).	Purchase required to read the full text. Claiming conformance in client contracts needs the licensed copy.
ISO/IEC 25010	Product quality model (quality attributes); revised 2023.	Purchase required.
ISO/IEC 27001	Information security management certification (2022 edition).	Standard is paid. Organisational certification is performed by accredited certification bodies; we offer readiness support only.
NIST CSF	Version 2.0 published February 2024.	Free; no certification.
OWASP Top 10 / ASVS	Periodically revised; always cite the edition year.	Free; no certification.
UML	OMG standard (UML 2.5.x), also an ISO/IEC standard.	OMG specs free; ISO text paid.
AWS / Azure / Google Cloud frameworks	Updated frequently; vendor-perspective guidance.	Free to read; vendor certifications optional and paid.

RULE

When a client contract names a standard, we obtain the licensed copy and cite the edition. We never quote from a paid standard beyond fair-use short references.

15. Reference Diagrams

Reusable reference diagrams for the fictional GreenLeaf Organics case. Treat as teaching examples; adapt to each client's evidence.

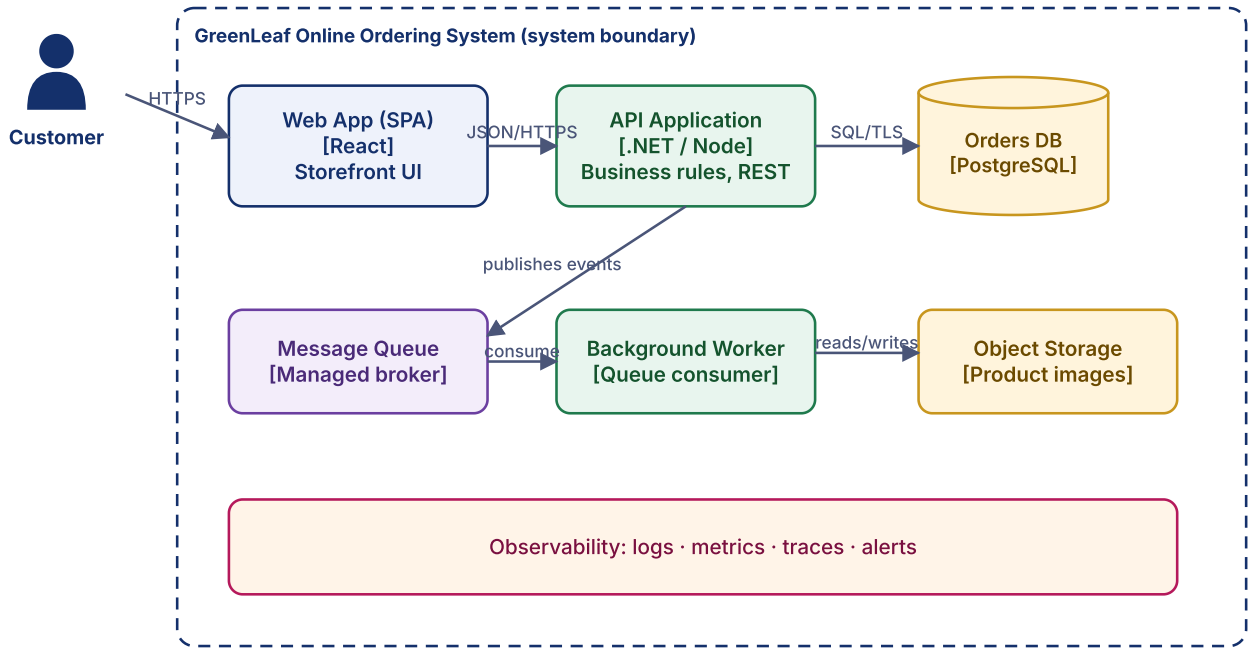


Figure 15.1 C4 Level 2: containers (training example).

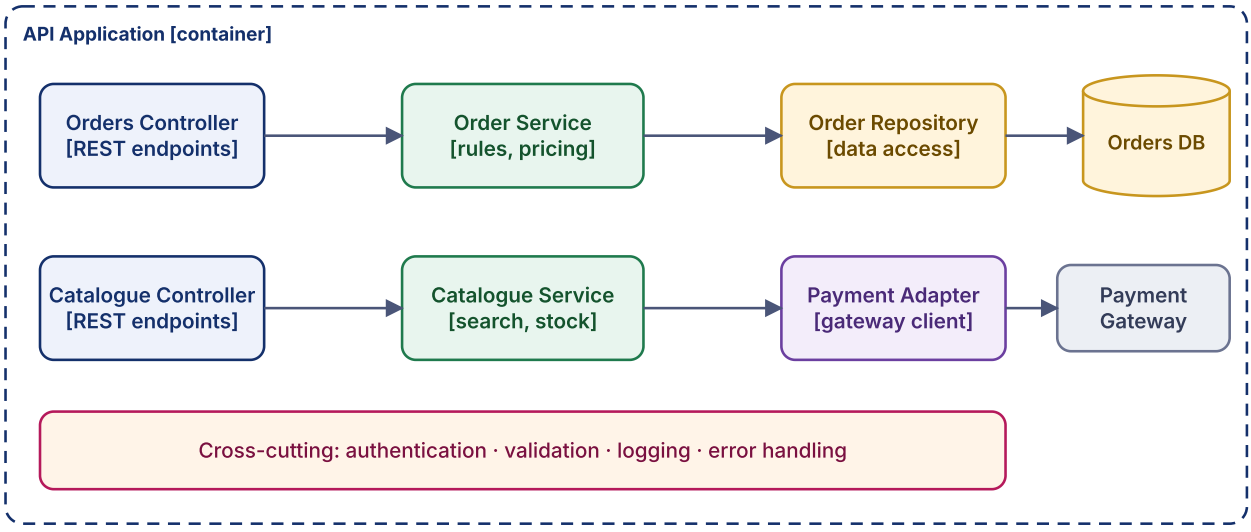


Figure 15.2 C4 Level 3: components of the API application.

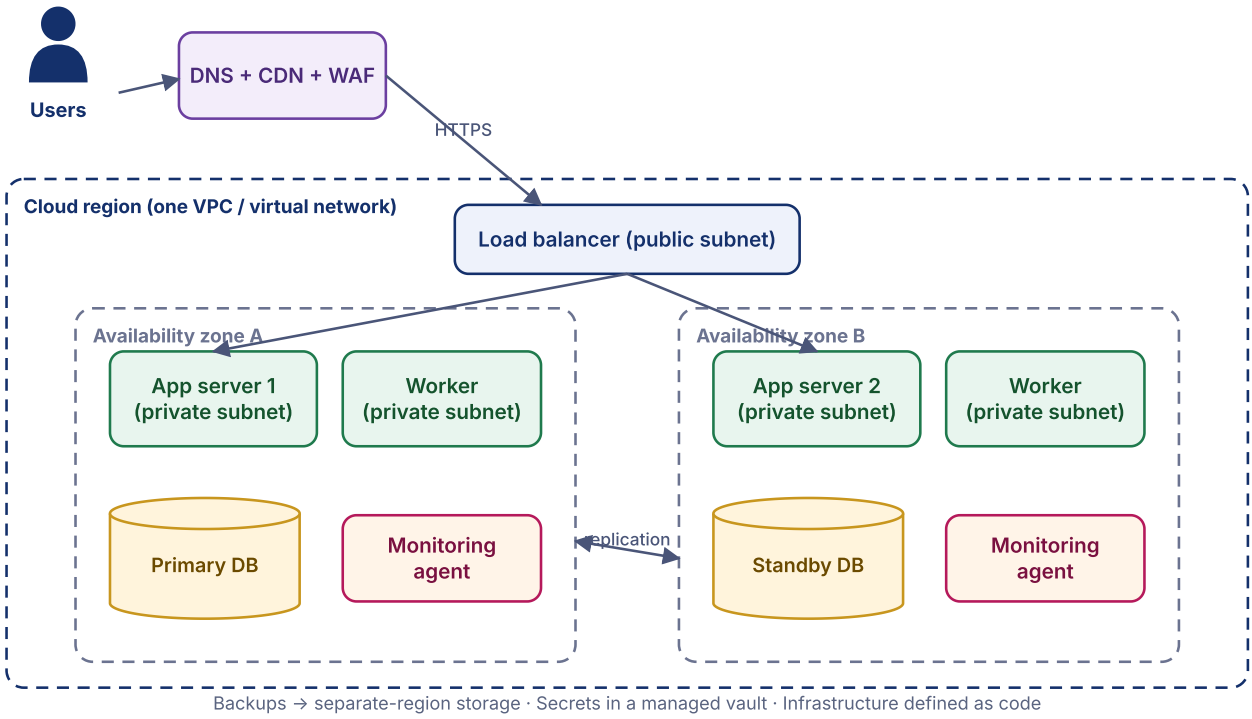


Figure 15.3 Deployment across two availability zones.

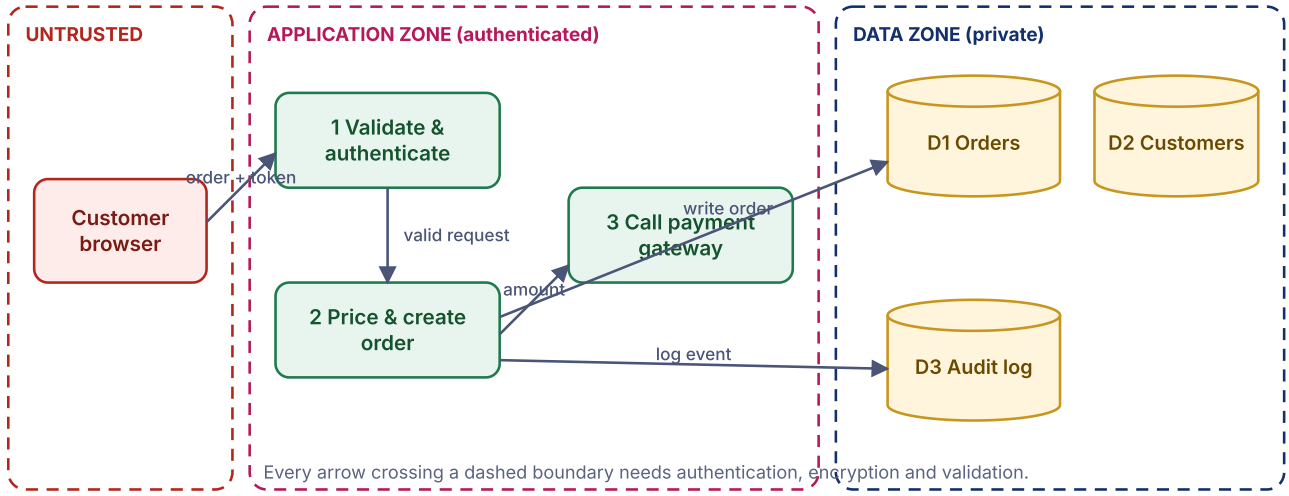


Figure 15.4 Data-flow diagram with trust boundaries.

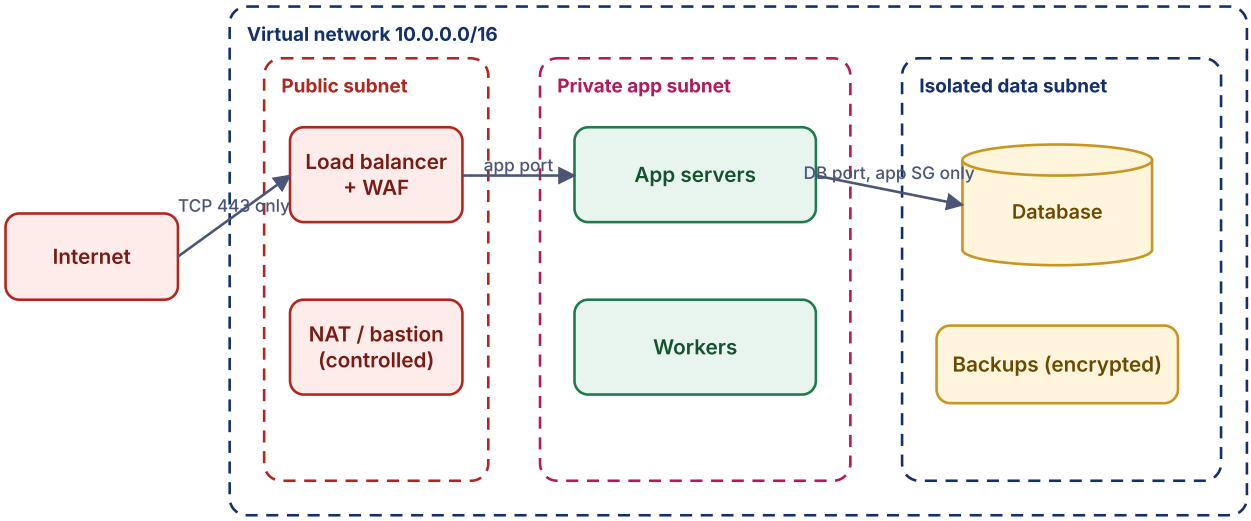


Figure 15.5 Network architecture and subnets.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
ADR	Architecture Decision Record.
API	Application Programming Interface; a contract between programs.
ARB	Architecture Review Board.
Availability	Share of time a service works as required.
Bounded context	DDD term: a boundary within which a model and its language are consistent.
C4	Context, Containers, Components, Code: four zoom levels of architecture diagrams.
Coupling	Degree of dependence between parts.
CQRS	Command Query Responsibility Segregation.
Container (C4)	A separately runnable unit such as a web app, API or database. Not necessarily Docker.
DR	Disaster recovery.
Event sourcing	Persisting state as a sequence of events.
IaC	Infrastructure as Code.
NFR	Non-functional requirement.
RPO	Recovery point objective: maximum acceptable data loss, measured in time.
RTO	Recovery time objective: maximum acceptable downtime.
SLA / SLO / SLI	Agreement / objective / indicator of service level.
SPOF	Single point of failure.
STRIDE	Spoofing, Tampering, Repudiation, Information disclosure, Denial of service, Elevation of privilege.
TCO	Total cost of ownership.
Technical debt	Shortcuts that increase future cost.
Trust boundary	Line across which data moves between different levels of trust.
Vendor lock-in	Cost of leaving a supplier.

Appendix A: 15-Part Lesson Template

Use for every syllabus subject. One row per part; keep each answer short and testable.

1. Definition	
2. Business relevance	
3. Technical purpose	
4. Real-world case	
5. Prerequisites	
6. Tools	
7. Step-by-step method	
8. Diagram	
9. Decision trade-offs	
10. Expected output	
11. Verification	
12. Common mistakes	
13. Documentation	
14. Assignment	
15. Review and approval	

Appendix B: Architecture Assessment Template

For Stage 03-04 assessments. Facts must be tagged **C** (confirmed, with source), **A** (assumed, with owner and date) or **U** (unknown).

Project / client	
Document ID and version	
Author / date	
Reviewer / date	
Approver / date	
Status (Draft / In review / Approved)	

1. Executive summary

Three paragraphs: situation, key findings, recommendation. No jargon. Max one page.

2. Scope and method

- In scope / out of scope
- Interviews held (who, when) and documents reviewed
- Evidence limits: what we could not see

3. Business context

- Objectives (measurable)
- Stakeholders and decision-makers
- Constraints (budget, date, skills, legal)

4. Current-state architecture

Area	Findings	Evidence / source	C/A/U

- Attach C4 L1 and L2 diagrams (as-is)
- Application and integration inventory
- Infrastructure, data, security, operations

5. Findings and risks

ID	Finding	Impact	Likelihood	Severity H/M/L	Recommendation

6. Quality attribute assessment

Attribute	Rating 1-5	Evidence	Key gap
Scalability			
Availability			
Reliability			
Performance			
Security			
Maintainability			
Interoperability			
Portability			
Cost			
Operability			

7. Options and recommendation

Summarise at least two options plus "do nothing"; link to the comparison matrix (Appendix G).

8. Roadmap and next steps

Phase	Actions	Owner	Timing	Cost range

9. Assumptions and unresolved decisions

ID	Statement	Owner	Confirm by	Status

VEL SOFTWARE SOLUTIONS

Appendix C: Client Discovery Questionnaire

Send before the first interview; complete together. Record who answered, the date, and tag each answer **C / A / U**. Ask for documents where answers exist.

Client / respondent	
Role	
Interviewer / scribe	
Date	

1. Organisation and objectives

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	What does the organisation do, and how does it make money or deliver value?		
2	What are the top three business objectives for the next 12-24 months?		
3	How will success of this project be measured (numbers)?		
4	Who is the executive sponsor and who makes the final decision?		
5	What happens if nothing changes?		

2. Stakeholders and process

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	Who uses the system today (roles, count)? Who will be affected by change?		
2	Which business processes does it support? Where are manual steps or workarounds?		
3	What are the busiest periods (daily, monthly, seasonal)?		

3. Current systems

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	List applications, owners, technologies and versions. Which are vendor-supported?		
2	Which systems exchange data? How (files, API, manual re-keying)?		
3	Where is it hosted (own premises, data centre, cloud)? Who administers it?		
4	Which databases and data volumes exist? How is data backed up and has restore been tested?		
5	What documentation exists and how current is it?		

4. Pain points and incidents

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	What are the top five technical problems? Which cost money or customers?		
2	Recent outages or security incidents: dates, causes, impact?		
3	How long does a release take? How often do releases fail?		

5. Requirements and quality

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	What must the new/changed system do that it cannot now?		
2	Expected users and transactions (today, in 3 years)?		
3	Acceptable downtime and data loss? Response-time expectations?		
4	Which data is personal, financial or confidential?		

6. Security and compliance

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	Which laws, standards or customer audits apply (e.g. data-protection law, ISO/IEC 27001, PCI DSS)?		
2	How are users authenticated and authorised? Is multi-factor authentication used?		
3	Any previous security assessments or penetration tests?		

7. Team, skills and operations

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	Size and skills of in-house IT/development team? Who is on call?		
2	Preferred technologies and any prohibited ones?		
3	Who will operate the solution after delivery?		

8. Budget, timeline and constraints

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	Budget range and funding approval process?		
2	Hard dates (events, contracts, regulations)?		
3	Procurement or vendor constraints (existing licences, cloud agreements)?		

9. Risks and expectations

#	Question	Answer	C/A/U
1	What worries you most about this project?		
2	What has been tried before and why did it fail?		
3	What would make you call this engagement a success?		

CONFIDENTIALITY

Information in this questionnaire is confidential and used only for the engagement under the signed NDA. Do not paste client answers into public tools.

Appendix D: Architecture Decision Record Template

Copy to `adr/NNNN-short-title.md`. One decision per record. Accepted ADRs are never edited; supersede them.

```
# ADR-NNNN: <short noun phrase describing the decision>

Status: Proposed | Accepted | Deprecated | Superseded by ADR-XXXX
Date: YYYY-MM-DD
Deciders: <names / roles>     Reviewer: <name>     Impact: Low | Medium | High

## Context
<The problem, forces and constraints. Link to requirement IDs. Mark facts CONFIRMED / ASSUMED /
UNKNOWN.>

## Options considered
1. <Option A>: summary, pros, cons, cost, risk
2. <Option B>: summary, pros, cons, cost, risk
3. <Do nothing / baseline>

## Decision
We will <choice>, because <reason tied to requirements and trade-offs>.

## Consequences
Positive: ...
Negative / risks: ...
Follow-up actions and owners: ...
Review trigger: <measurable condition that means we should revisit>

## Compliance and links
Related requirements: REQ-..., NFR-...   Related ADRs: ...   Evidence: <links>
```

Quality checklist

- [ ] Two or more real options plus baseline
- [ ] Trade-offs include downsides
- [ ] Linked to requirements
- [ ] Assumptions labelled
- [ ] Review trigger defined
- [ ] Reviewed by a second person; approved by authority matching the impact level

Appendix E: Requirements Specification Template

Project / client	
Document ID and version	
Author / date	
Reviewer / date	
Approver / date	
Status (Draft / In review / Approved)	

1. Purpose and scope

What the system is for; boundaries; link to context diagram. Out of scope list.

2. Stakeholders

Name / role	Interest	Influence	Contact

3. Business objectives

ID	Objective	Measure and target	Source

4. Functional requirements

ID	The system shall...	Priority (M/S/C)	Acceptance criteria (Given/When/Then)	Source	Status C/A/U
FR-001					
FR-002					

ID	The system shall…	Priority (M/S/C)	Acceptance criteria (Given/When/Then)	Source	Status C/A/U
FR-003					
FR-004					

5. Non-functional requirements

ID	Attribute	Requirement with number	Measure / test	Priority	Status
NFR-001	Performance				
NFR-002	Availability				
NFR-003	Security				
NFR-004	Scalability				
NFR-005	Recovery (RPO/RTO)				
NFR-006	Maintainability				

6. Constraints

ID	Constraint	Type (budget, date, skill, legal, tech)	Status C/A

7. Assumptions and dependencies

ID	Statement	Impact if wrong	Owner	Confirm by

8. Traceability matrix

Objective	Requirement IDs	Design element	Test / acceptance

9. Sign-off

Name	Role	Signature	Date

Appendix F: Technical Feasibility Report Template

Project / client	
Document ID and version	
Author / date	
Reviewer / date	
Approver / date	
Status (Draft / In review / Approved)	

1. Question being assessed

One sentence: "Can we ... within ... by ... for ...?"

2. Summary conclusion

Result	Select one
Feasible	[ ]
Feasible with conditions (list)	[ ]
Not feasible (reasons)	[ ]
Cannot conclude: evidence needed	[ ]

3. Feasibility dimensions

Dimension	Rating (High/Med/Low)	Evidence	Risks / conditions
Technical			
Economic (cost-benefit)			
Schedule			
Legal and compliance			
Operational			
Skills and staffing			

Dimension	Rating (High/Med/Low)	Evidence	Risks / conditions
Security and data protection			
Vendor / licence			

4. Proofs of concept and spikes

Spike	Question	Time-box	Result	Decision

5. Cost range

Item	One-time	Recurring / year	Source and date

6. Risks

ID	Risk	L	I	Mitigation	Owner

7. Assumptions and unresolved decisions

ID	Statement	Owner	Confirm by

8. Recommendation and next step

What to do, by whom, by when, and what decision is needed from the sponsor.

Appendix G: Technology Comparison Matrix

Method: (1) agree criteria and weights with the client **before** scoring; (2) score each option 1-5 with evidence; (3) weighted score = Σ(weight x score); (4) run sensitivity: change weights ±20% and see if the winner changes; (5) the highest score is an input to the recommendation, not the recommendation itself.

Decision to be made	
Options (min. two + baseline)	
Date, authors, reviewer	

Criterion	Weight (sum = 100)	Option A score	Option B score	Option C / baseline	Evidence / notes
Requirement fit					
Security					
Scalability					
Availability / reliability					
Maintainability and skills					
Total cost (3 years)					
Vendor lock-in (5 = low)					
Operational complexity (5 = low)					
Delivery time / risk					
Ecosystem and support					
Weighted total	**100**				

Example scoring (training)

Criterion	Weight	Modular monolith	Microservices	Low-code SaaS
Requirement fit	20	4	5	3
Total cost (3 years)	20	4	2	4
Operational complexity	15	5	1	5

Criterion	Weight	Modular monolith	Microservices	Low-code SaaS
Delivery time / risk	15	4	2	5
Scalability	10	3	5	3
Security	10	4	4	3
Vendor lock-in	10	4	3	2
Weighted total (max 500)	100	**405**	**305**	**370**

Calculation, modular monolith: 20×4 + 20×4 + 15×5 + 15×4 + 10×3 + 10×4 + 10×4 = 80+80+75+60+30+40+40 = **405**. Microservices = **305**; low-code = **370**.

REMINDER

Low-code scores close to the monolith here. If the client values speed over customisation, or lock-in weight drops, it could win. State this in the recommendation.

Appendix H: Risk and Assumption Register Template

ID	Risk	Cause	Likelihood (1-5)	Impact (1-5)	Score	Mitigation	Owner	Status

Score = likelihood x impact. 15-25 high (act now), 8-14 medium (plan), 1-7 low (watch). Review weekly.

ID	Assumption	Why we believe it	Impact if wrong	Owner	Confirm by	Status

Appendix I: Stakeholder Map Template

Stakeholder	Role	Interest	Influence (H/M/L)	Attitude	Engagement plan	Owner

Grid: **High influence + high interest** = manage closely · high influence + low interest = keep satisfied · low influence + high interest = keep informed · low/low = monitor.

Appendix J: Architecture Review Checklist

Project / document under review	
Reviewer (not the author)	
Date	
Outcome: Approved / Approved with conditions / Rejected	

Requirement coverage

- [ ] Every MUST requirement traced to design
- [ ] NFRs quantified
- [ ] Acceptance criteria exist

Architecture consistency

- [ ] Diagrams, ADRs and specs agree
- [ ] Terminology consistent
- [ ] C4 levels not mixed

Security boundaries

- [ ] Trust boundaries drawn
- [ ] Authentication and authorisation designed
- [ ] Secrets management defined
- [ ] Threat model reviewed

Data protection

- [ ] Data classified
- [ ] Encryption in transit and at rest decided
- [ ] Retention and deletion defined
- [ ] Privacy owner consulted

Scalability and performance

- [ ] Load model and targets
- [ ] Bottleneck identified
- [ ] Test plan

Availability and failure handling

- [ ] Single points of failure removed or accepted
- [ ] Timeouts, retries, idempotency
- [ ] Graceful degradation

Observability

- [ ] Logs, metrics, traces
- [ ] Alerts with owners
- [ ] Dashboards

Backup and recovery

- [ ] RPO/RTO defined
- [ ] Backups separate from primary
- [ ] Restore tested or test planned

Operational complexity

- [ ] Client can operate it
- [ ] Runbooks planned
- [ ] Support model defined

Cost

- [ ] Estimate has sources and dates
- [ ] Independent review
- [ ] Cost-control measures

Maintainability and vendor dependency

- [ ] Module boundaries clear
- [ ] Lock-in assessed with exit plan
- [ ] Technical debt visible

Implementation feasibility

- [ ] Skills available
- [ ] Timeline realistic
- [ ] Dependencies identified

Findings log

#	Finding	Severity (Critical/High/Med/Low)	Owner	Due	Resolution

RULE

No approval while a Critical or unaccepted High finding is open. Document accepted risks with the sponsor's name and date.

Appendix K: Cost Estimation Template

Companion spreadsheet with live formulas: **Cost-Estimation-Template.xlsx**. Use the same structure on paper. Currency: _____ · Tax basis: _____ · Estimate date: _____.

1. Effort (delivery cost)

Activity	Role	Hours	Cost/h	Cost

2. Direct expenses

Item	Amount	Basis

3. Pricing calculation

Line	Formula	Value
Delivery cost (DC)	Σ effort + expenses	
Risk reserve	risk % x DC	
Selling price	(DC + reserve) / (1 − target GM)	
Gross margin %	(Price − DC) / Price	
Contribution margin	Price − DC − variable costs − reserve	
Stress GM at +25% effort	(Price − 1.25 x DC) / Price	

4. Client run-cost estimate (cloud)

Service / component	Quantity and size	Region	Monthly low	Monthly high	Calculator link and date

Service / component	Quantity and size	Region	Monthly low	Monthly high	Calculator link and date

Include compute, storage, database, network/data transfer, backup, monitoring, support plan, licences and tax. Present as a **range** and state it is an estimate; the client's bill depends on usage.

5. Three-year TCO of options

Cost	Option A	Option B	Baseline
Build (one-time)			
Infrastructure (3 yrs)			
Licences (3 yrs)			
Support and operations (3 yrs)			
Training			
Risk contingency			
Total			

Appendix L: Client Presentation Template

Present in business language. One message per slide. Rehearse with a senior reviewer. Send a written follow-up within 24 hours.

Slide	Content guidance
1. Title and purpose	Client name, engagement, date, presenters, what decision we need today.
2. Executive summary	Problem, recommendation, cost range, timeline, risk, decisions needed: on one slide.
3. Business context	Objectives, constraints and what success looks like in the client's words.
4. Where you are today	C4 Level 1 as-is; 3-5 key findings with evidence.
5. Requirements that matter most	Top 5-8 requirements with numbers; assumptions flagged.
6. Options considered	Two or three options plus "do nothing", each in business terms.
7. Comparison and trade-offs	Weighted matrix; honest strengths and weaknesses.
8. Recommended architecture	C4 L1 and L2 to-be diagrams; one-sentence explanation of each part.
9. Security and data protection	Trust boundaries and controls in plain language; what remains the client's responsibility.
10. Cost	One-time and recurring ranges; assumptions; how we estimated.
11. Risks and mitigations	Top 5 with owners.
12. Roadmap	Phases, milestones, team needs, decision gates.
13. Decisions we need from you	Numbered list with owners and dates.
14. Next steps	First 30 days; contacts.
Appendix	Detail diagrams, ADR list, assumptions register, glossary.

LANGUAGE RULES

Say "customer database" not "RDS cluster"; "can fail over automatically" not "multi-AZ"; explain any acronym once. Show trade-offs honestly: a recommendation that hides its downside is not trusted.

Presentation checklist

- [ ] Every number has a source and date
- [ ] Assumptions slide included
- [ ] No guarantees on uptime, savings or security

- [ ] Decision requests are explicit
- [ ] Rehearsed; questions anticipated
- [ ] Fictional/anonymised data only in demos

Appendix M: Engineering Handover Checklist

Project	
Approved architecture version / Git tag	
Handover date	
Handed over by / received by	

Common

- [ ] Approved architecture pack (diagrams, ADRs, requirements) shared with links
- [ ] Open risks, assumptions and unresolved decisions listed with owners
- [ ] Definition of done and acceptance criteria agreed
- [ ] Governance cadence and escalation path agreed
- [ ] Change process explained (new ADR to deviate)

Development team

- [ ] Component and interface specifications
- [ ] Coding and API standards
- [ ] Module boundaries and allowed dependencies (architecture tests)
- [ ] Backlog seeds traced to requirements
- [ ] Non-functional test targets

Cloud / infrastructure team

- [ ] Deployment and network diagrams
- [ ] Environment matrix (dev/test/prod) and sizing assumptions
- [ ] IaC module structure and state management
- [ ] Backup, DR, RPO/RTO and restore-test plan
- [ ] Cost budget and alerts

Data team

- [ ] ERD and data dictionary
- [ ] Data classification, retention and deletion rules
- [ ] Migration approach and reconciliation checks
- [ ] Reporting and analytics requirements

API / integration team

- [ ] OpenAPI / AsyncAPI contracts
- [ ] Versioning, error and rate-limit policy
- [ ] Retry, idempotency and dead-letter handling
- [ ] Interface catalogue with owners and SLAs

Security team

- [ ] Trust boundaries and threat model
- [ ] Authentication and authorisation design
- [ ] Secrets and key management
- [ ] Logging and monitoring requirements
- [ ] Security testing plan

Operations and support

- [ ] Monitoring, alerting and dashboards
- [ ] Runbooks and on-call model
- [ ] Incident and change process
- [ ] Training for client operators

Acknowledgement

Team	Name	Questions raised	Signature	Date
Development				
Cloud				
Data				
API / integration				
Security				
Operations				